

LG approves executive magistrate powers for revenue officers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu has authorised key revenue and administrative officers to exercise executive magistrate powers in the reorganised districts of the national Capital. The powers will be conferred upon Deputy Commissioners/District Magistrates (DMs), Additional District Magistrates (ADMs), Revenue Assistants, Tehsildars, and Consolidation Officers within their respective reorganised jurisdictions. After the reorganisation

process, the number of districts in the National Capital Territory of Delhi (GNCTD) rose from 11 to 13. In a statement, Lok Niwas said the appointment is being executed under Section 14 of the Bharatiya Nagrik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023, which has replaced the erstwhile Code of Criminal Procedure (Cr.P.C.). Section 14 empowers the "State Government" to appoint executive magistrates, designate DMs/ADMs, and place magistrates in charge of sub-divisions. Under the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), Government of India's notification dated June

28, 2024, the powers and functions of the "State Government" under the BNSS (except Section 523) stand delegated to the Lt Governor of Delhi. Following the Revenue Department's district reorganisation notification dated December 25, 2025, the formal conferment of these magistrate powers became imperative to ensure seamless administrative governance, maintenance of law and order, and public service delivery across the newly structured districts. The Home Minister and Chief Minister, GNCTD, had



approved the proposal before recommending it to the LG. With the Lt Governor's formal assent, the official notification under Section 14 of the BNSS, 2023, will be issued by the Government. In a major restructuring of administrative boundaries, the Delhi Government last

year approved the reorganisation of the capital's 11 revenue districts into 13, bringing them in line with its municipal zones. Three new districts — Old Delhi, Central North and Outer North — have been created, and Shahdara has been scrapped. Ten districts — South East, North, New Delhi, Central, South West, North West, North East, East, South and West - have been retained, but with revised boundaries. Calling it a "historic step" and stating that "no previous government addressed this long-pending requirement", Chief Minister Rekha Gupta

had stated that the move will lead to "improved coordination of services, quicker delivery, faster grievance redressal and effective monitoring". Model Town, an earlier part of North, falls under the newly created Central North district. Chandni Chowk and Sadar Bazar, earlier in Central, are now two subdivisions of the same name in Old Delhi district. Another major change was the shifting of Patel Nagar from the west to the central district to clear persistent confusion over its jurisdiction, given its proximity to the central part of the city. Shahdara district, which

comprised Shahdara, Vivek Vihar and Seemapuri, has been scrapped, and its areas have been redistributed, with most parts merged into North East and East districts. In the North East district, the number of sub-divisions has been increased from three to four — Karawal Nagar, Gokulpuri, Yamuna Vihar and Shahdara. The Seelampur sub-division has been abolished, and its areas redistributed among neighbouring units. The South district now has four sub-divisions — Chhatarpur, Malviya Nagar, Deoli and Mehrauli.

CM joins Yamuna cleaning drive, calls for people's participation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday joined a large number of young people, volunteers, social organisations and local residents in a shramdaan drive at the Yamuna Ghat in Chilla Village as part of the 'Clean Delhi with CM' cleanliness campaign. By personally participating in the cleaning drive at the ghat, the Chief Minister conveyed the message of public participation in keeping the Yamuna clean. On the occasion, she said that the Yamuna is not merely a river but Delhi's memory, culture and life-line. Keeping it clean, pure and free-flowing is not just the responsibility of the government but the shared responsibility of every



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta during a cleanliness drive at Chilla village for the Yamuna Ghat in New Delhi

citizen. She said that the Yamuna, which has remained a centre of faith for millions of people for centuries, is today facing the challenge of pollution, and restoring it to a clean and pristine state is a shared responsibility of both the Government and society. The Chief Minister said

that the Delhi Government is continuously working towards the scientific, sustainable and comprehensive rejuvenation of the Yamuna and that the clean ghats are a living testament to that commitment. On one hand, the Government is rapidly modernising sewage treatment plants, setting up

a people's movement. She said the Delhi Government is setting up dedicated collection centres (portacabins) across different parts of the city for the respectful disposal of puja materials and damaged idols. These materials will then undergo scientific and systematic recycling, ensuring both respect for religious sentiments and effective waste management. The Chief Minister announced that, to strengthen public participation further, the Delhi Government will organise public campaigns every Sunday, including cleanliness drives, Yamuna cleaning campaigns and tree plantation programmes. During the campaign, the chief minister also interacted with volunteers and young environmentalists.

Four siblings arrested as police bust major drug syndicate in Jahangirpuri

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police busted a major drug syndicate allegedly operating out of Jahangirpuri, arresting four siblings and seizing psychotropic drugs, cash, jewellery and property documents collectively worth several crores of rupees. The Anti-Narcotics Squad of the North-West District, with assistance from the Drugs Control Department, conducted an overnight operation at multiple locations in Jahangirpuri, arresting Paro (28), Usha (25), Kanta (35) and their brother Amit (30). Police alleged the siblings ran an organised network involved in the illegal storage and distribution of psychotropic substances across Delhi.



According to police, the raids resulted in the recovery of 1,300 Addnok-N tablets containing Buprenorphine and Naloxone, prohibited under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, weighing a total of 268 grams. Officers also recovered 735 Avil injections and 2,532 needles and syringes, allegedly supplied for drug abuse. Investigators further seized ₹22.2 lakh in cash, 241 grams of gold jewellery valued at around ₹35 lakh and 2.4 kg of silver jewellery worth approximately ₹6.2 lakh. Documents related to 11 flats, each estimated at ₹12-15 lakh, and a brand-new TVS scooter registered in the name of one of the accused were also seized as suspected proceeds of crime.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, **Vijay Sharma S/o Sh. Shil Ganga Sharma** R/o H-B1-201, Classic Residency, Rajnagar Extension, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201001, have changed my name from Vijay Kumar to Vijay Sharma. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Vijay Sharma for all future purposes.

PD(1499)C
I, **Naresh Kumar S/o Bhagavan Singh**, R/o A-101, Tower-A, 1st Floor, Prabhat Heights, Dhundhera, Sector 6C, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh- 201016, have changed my name from Naresh Kumar to Naresh Kumar Sisodia. Henceforth, I would be known by the name of Naresh Kumar Sisodia for all future purposes.

PD(1500)C
I, **No.14669222N Hav Rangappa** Dodamani, R/o-At/Post- Kappalguddi, Teh-Raybag, Dist- Belagavi, Karnataka- 591235, have changed my Daughter's name from Sneha to Sneha Rangappa Dodamani, vide affidavit dated 27/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1501)C

I, **No. 14830872P Hav/MT** Jahenda Singh Baghel, R/o-Vill & PO- Chiruli, Teh- Dabra, Dist- Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh- 475005, have changed my son's name from Sourabh Singh Baghel to Saurabh Singh Baghel, vide affidavit dated 27/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1502)C
I, **No.14669222N Hav** Rangappa Dodamani, R/o-At/Post- Kappalguddi, Teh-Raybag, Dist- Belagavi, Karnataka- 591235, have changed my Son's name from Akash to Akash Rangappa Dodamani, vide affidavit dated 27/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1503)C
I, **No. 15701942F Hav Ganpat** Lal Lohar, R/o- Vill- Bangred, Teh- Jawad, Dist- Neemuch (M.P.)Pin- 458220, have c.hanged my Son's name from Aayansh Lohar to Aditya Lohar, vide affidavit dated 27/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1504)C

Govt to institute Sant Kabir awards, competitions to inspire youth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government organised a state-level celebration on Sunday to mark the birth anniversary of Sant Kabir Das. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced that competitions and awards will be instituted in the saint-poet's name to promote his teachings among the younger generation. She said Sant Kabir Das's ideals of social harmony, equality and humanity remain as relevant today as



they were centuries ago. She said the initiative aims to familiarise youth with Kabir's teachings, couplets and message of brotherhood while strengthening the values of national unity and human dignity. The Chief Minister said Delhi symbolises India's diversity and cultural unity, where every individual deserves equal opportunity and dignity. Union Minister of State for Social Justice and Empowerment BL Verma, Delhi Social Welfare and

SC/ST/OBC Welfare Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh, MLA Neelam Pahalwan, representatives of social and religious organisations, scholars, senior

officials and members of the saint community also attended the event. Speaking on the occasion, Ravinder Indraj Singh said

Police arrest drug supplier, recover smack worth ₹25 lakh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Anti-Narcotics Squad (ANS) of Delhi Police's Outer District arrested an alleged drug supplier and seized 206 grams of smack, valued at around ₹25 lakh in the illegal market, during a crack-down on organised narcotics trafficking. According to police, they apprehended the accused, identified as 28-year-old Karan, a resident of Nihal Vihar, near Tyagi Chowk in Shiv Vihar, under the Ranhola police



station's jurisdiction, following a tip-off. Police said that on June 27, an ANS team was patrolling in Ranhola when it received specific intelligence that a man would arrive near the T-point at Tyagi Chowk to deliver a consignment of smack. Acting swiftly on the information, the team laid a trap at the spot. After some time, the suspect was seen approaching from the Shiv Vihar side. As soon as he noticed the police personnel, he allegedly attempted to flee but was

chased down and overpowered by the raiding team. During his personal search, officers recovered a suspected narcotic substance. An FSL team was called to the scene, and the substance was tested with a field-testing kit, which confirmed it was smack. The recovered contraband weighed 206 grams, an intermediate quantity under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act. Police sealed the seized narcotics at the spot after completing the required legal formalities. Police at Ranhola station registered a case under Section 21 of the NDPS Act and formally arrested the accused. Officials said the estimated value of the recovered smack in the illicit market is approximately

₹25 lakh. DCP Vikram Singh noted that the arrest is part of the Outer District Police's ongoing drive against organised narcotics trafficking and illegal drug distribution in the national Capital. Police said further investigation is underway to trace the source of the seized narcotics and identify other members of the supply chain. Investigators are also probing whether the accused has links with larger drug trafficking networks operating in Delhi and neighbouring States.

DMRC wins UITP award for operational excellence

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) won the Achievement Award in the Operational Excellence category from the International Association of Public Transport (UITP) for its smart door-to-door travel service, according to a statement on Sunday. The award recognises DMRC's efforts to improve sustainable urban transport through an integrated travel service that combines first-and-last-mile connectivity, real-time travel information and seamless ticketing for commuters, the statement said. The service is available through the DMRC Sarthi App, an AI-powered platform. It enables commuters to plan and book their complete journey from their point of origin to their final destination, the corporation said. The award was presented during the UITP Awards Ceremony held in Brussels on June 23, the statement said. According to it, the UITP award recognises public transport organisations that demonstrate outstanding performance, innovation and impact in delivering day-to-day public transport services. The award was received on behalf of DMRC by Director (Operations and Services) Amit Kumar Jain and Additional General Manager (Operations) Rajnish Rana, it said.

Man gets life imprisonment after 12 years for killing vendor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Twelve years after a man shot dead a vendor for not serving him 'jalebis' ahead of others in a queue in Delhi, a court sentenced him to life imprisonment. On February 18, 2014, at a sweet shop near Bangla Sahib Gurudwara, when the vendor refused to cut line, the man slapped him, took out his pistol and fired from close range at his head. Additional Sessions Judge Dharendra Rana was hearing arguments on the sentencing of Neeraj, who had been convicted earlier this month under IPC Section 302 (murder) and under the Arms Act for unauthorised use of firearms. In an order dated June 8, the judge said, "Perusal of the record narrates that the convict entered into a quarrel with the deceased as he wanted that jalebis would be given to him before other customers, who were standing in the queue. "When the deceased (vendor) refused the same, the convict slapped him and took out a pistol and fired a gunshot from close range on the head of the deceased." He noted that the deceased was shifted to a hospital, where he expired and that Neeraj was apprehended near the spot, and a fake arms license was recovered from him. "I have considered the mitigating circumstances involved in this case. Convict is not involved in any other case. He remained in custody throughout the trial. He is not a threat to society, and there are chances of his reformation."

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E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE
(Under SARFAESI Act 2002)

APPENDIX- IV-A (SEE PROVISO TO RULE 8(6) SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES)
E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to the Central Bank of India (secured creditor), the constructive/ physical Possession of which have been taken by the authorized officer of Central Bank of India (Secured creditors), **will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on date 06.08.2026** for recovery of dues to the **Central Bank of India** from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and Earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties.

E-AUCTION SCHEDULED TO BE HELD ON 06.08.2026 (30 DAY'S NOTICE)

S. No.	Name of Branch	Authorised Officer/ Branch Head	Name of the Account	Description of Property & Owner Name	Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (In Rupees)	Date & Type of Possession	In Rupees Reserve Price EMD Bid Increase
1.	Karolbagh New Delhi	Mr. Vinay Kumar MOBILE: 9999917126	RAMESH NAGPAL	Residential Flat Built Up Second Floor with Roof/ Terrace Rights, Built on Back Side Portion of Free Hold Property Bearing No WZ-283/11, Plot No.- 11, Area Measuring 50 Sq yards, Out of Khasra No 18/2/2, Situated in the Area of Village- Khyala, now Abadi known as Vishnu Garden, West Block- New Delhi-110018, Owner-Mr. Ramesh Nagpal S/o Mr. Laxman Dass	Rs.11,91,517.00 on 25.05.2022 + interest thereafter	28.04.2026 (Physical)	₹ 22,00,000.00 ₹ 2,20,000.00 ₹ 20,000.00

E-AUCTION DATE: 06.08.2026, TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 04:00 PM WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES
Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 06.08.2026 Upto 03:30 PM.
Bidder will register on website: <https://BAANKNET.com> and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in **BAANKNET** EMD wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer / Generation of challan from (<https://BAANKNET.com>). The auction will be conducted through common landing platform **BAANKNET.com Portal** (<https://BAANKNET.com>). E-auction will be held "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis. **Property shall be sold only above the Reserve Price. (All other charges/ dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser).** For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in www.centralbank.bank.in Secured Creditor or auction platform (<https://BAANKNET.com>). **Helpline: (+91) 8291220220, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com**
STATUTORY 30 DAY'S SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) OF THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002
Borrowers/Guarantors/ Mortgagees are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.
DATE: 25.06.2026
PLACE: NEW DELHI

Authorised Officer,
CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA, RO Delhi (South), New Delhi

Delhi records warmest morning in 2 years amid monsoon delay

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi recorded its warmest morning in two years on Sunday, with the minimum temperature settling at 31.1 degrees Celsius, 3.2 notches above the seasonal average, while the maximum climbed to 41.8 degrees Celsius amid a delay in the arrival of the southwest monsoon, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

The last time the city's minimum temperature was higher was on June 14, 2024, when it was recorded at 33.3 degrees Celsius. According to the weather office, a heat-wave has been realised over Delhi, and the 'feels-like' temperature was around 48 to 53 degrees Celsius. Relative humidity was recorded at

44 per cent at 5.30 pm. The heat index, also called the apparent temperature or "feels like" temperature, is a single figure that tells you how hot the weather feels to a human being. It blends two ingredients: the air temperature and the relative humidity. Relative humidity is simply how full of moisture the air is. Picture the air as a sponge. Relative humidity tells you what fraction of that sponge is already soaked.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the last time the city's minimum temperature was higher was on June 14, 2024, when it was recorded at 33.3 degrees Celsius. The weather office said a heatwave has been realised over Delhi, and the maximum temperature at 5.30 pm was around 50.7

degrees Celsius. The maximum temperature at Safdarjung, the city's base station, was 41.8 degrees Celsius, 4.6 notches above normal. The minimum temperature was 31.1 degrees Celsius, the IMD said.

Other weather stations also recorded high maximum temperatures, with Palam at 42 degrees Celsius, Lodhi Road at 42.1 degrees Celsius, Ridge at 42.6 degrees Celsius and Ayanagar at 41.8 degrees Celsius. The minimum temperature remained above normal across all five IMD observatories in the city.

The minimum temperature in Palam recorded 30 degrees Celsius, followed by 30.2 degrees Celsius at Lodhi Road, 28.7 degrees Celsius at Ridge and 29 degrees Celsius at Ayanagar. The departures



from the seasonal average ranged from 1.4 degrees Celsius at Ayanagar to 3.2 degrees Celsius each at Safdarjung and Lodhi Road. Relative humidity was

recorded at 44 per cent at 5.30 pm. The result is sticky heat, not dry heat, and sticky heat is far harder for the body to shed. Weather forecasting

agency Skymet said the delay in the onset of the monsoon and the interaction of dry and moist winds have kept both temperatures and humidity unusually high. "Normally,

the monsoon reaches Delhi around June 27-28, after which temperatures begin to ease and humidity increases. This year, however, the monsoon is likely to be delayed by about a week. Dry westerly winds from Pakistan are keeping temperatures high, while southwesterly winds from the Arabian Sea are also reaching Delhi and increasing humidity," said Mahesh Palawat, vice president (meteorology and climate change), Skymet.

"When these dry and moist air masses interact, clouds do form, but there is not enough moisture for widespread rainfall. By the time cloud formation takes place, usually around 4 or 5 pm, the day's maximum temperature has already been recorded. That is why both the maximum

temperature and the 'feel-like' temperature have remained unusually high," he said. Palawat said the monsoon is expected to advance into east Uttar Pradesh by June 30 or July 1, reach Uttarakhand around July 2 or 3, and arrive in Delhi around July 4 if conditions remain favourable.

"We are also expecting a small cyclonic circulation to develop over the next few days, which could trigger isolated spells of rain," he added.

The IMD forecasts thunderstorms with rain on Monday, with maximum and minimum temperatures expected to settle at 41 degrees Celsius. The air quality was recorded in the 'moderate' category, with an Air Quality Index (AQI) of 162, according to the Sameer app.

75% of Government work now on e-Office

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 75 per cent of the Delhi Government's paperwork has shifted to an online e-Office platform covering 177 departments and around 15,700 active users in the last year.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said in a statement that one year of e-Office implementation has reduced dependence on paper files and enhanced transparency in governance. The use of e-Office was made mandatory across all Delhi Government departments from July 1, 2025.

At present, all 132 Government departments are part of the system, with 11,940 active users. Since April 13, 2026, 120 of the 132 government departments, about 91 per cent, have been using e-Office regularly.

Similarly, 36 of the 55 public sector undertakings, boards, corporations, commissions, committees, autonomous and local bodies, or about 65.5 per cent, are using the system.

Among universities, colleges and other educational institutions, 21 out of 48



institutions, or about 43.8 per cent, have adopted e-Office. Overall, 177 of the 232 departments and offices, about 75.3 per cent, are now regularly carrying out official work through the e-Office system.

Earlier, most official work was carried out through paper files. Today, file movement, correspondence and approvals are handled online. This has accelerated file disposal, improved transparency and accountability in government functioning, and helped ensure the timely delivery of public services.

The Chief Minister said the system has also made

record-keeping more secure, reduced unnecessary delays and enabled smoother coordination among departments. This is why the Delhi Government is steadily expanding the system to cover more departments and institutions.

She said that as of March 8, 2025, 5,005 officers and employees across 198 departments and offices were using e-Office for online file processing and official work. By June 27, 2026, the number had risen to 15,748 officers and employees across 235 departments and offices.

According to the chief

minister, since the functioning of all departments and institutions is not the same, the Delhi Government has developed the e-Office system under three separate categories.

The first is meant exclusively for government departments, the second for public sector undertakings, boards, corporations, commissions, committees, autonomous bodies and local bodies, and the third for universities, colleges and other educational institutions. This has enabled each category to function more effectively according to its specific requirements. Accordingly, the use of e-Office was made mandatory across all Delhi Government departments from July 1, 2025. At present, all 132 government departments are part of the system, with 11,940 active users.

The Chief Minister said that between July 1, 2025, and April 12, 2026, Government departments processed 1,14,603 e-files and 7,14,091 e-receipts. Following the launch of the new e-Office system, nearly 23,767 e-files and 1.53 lakh e-receipts were processed

between April 13, 2026, and June 27, 2026, alone, reflecting the rapid increase in its adoption across departments. She added that 3,090 active users are currently working through e-Office across 55 public sector undertakings, boards, corporations, commissions, committees, autonomous bodies and local bodies.

Between April 15, 2026, and June 27, 2026, these institutions processed 4,672 e-files and 55,132 e-receipts. Similarly, 718 active users are using e-Office across 48 universities, colleges and other educational institutions. Between April 17, 2026, and June 27, 2026, these institutions processed 1,267 e-files and 3,051 e-receipts.

The chief minister said the Delhi Government's objective is to create a work environment across all government offices where administration is faster, more transparent and more accountable, while ensuring that people do not have to wait unnecessarily for Government services.

She said the e-Office system has emerged as an important step in this direction.

5-year-old girl dies after falling from 10th-floor balcony in Kalkaji Extension

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A five-year-old girl died after allegedly falling from the 10th floor of a residential apartment building in southeast Delhi's Kalkaji Extension.

Police said that they are probing all possible angles and examining CCTV footage to ascertain the sequence of events. According to police, a PCR call reporting the incident was received at the Govindpuri police station at around 7 pm, following which a police team rushed to the spot. The child lived with her family in Asha Kiran Apartments, a 14-storey residential complex developed by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA).

According to preliminary investigation, the child had gone to sleep earlier in the evening but woke up while her parents were occupied with household work. As she could not find her mother, she allegedly walked towards the balcony and leaned over the railing while looking down and accidentally slipped, police said.



She was rushed to a nearby hospital, where doctors declared her brought dead. Her father, Mithun Das, runs a fish shop in the area. The girl's father, who works at a local fish market, was reportedly at work when the incident occurred, while her mother had gone to a neighbour's house.

Police said a crime team inspected the spot, and CCTV cameras installed in and around the apartment complex are being scanned to reconstruct the events leading to the fall.

Investigators are also recording statements of family members, neighbours and other residents. The child's family blamed the lack of ade-

quate safety measures in the high-rise building for the tragedy.

"If protective safety grills or netting had been installed in the balconies, our child might have been alive today. Such buildings must have proper safety arrangements for children," a family member said.

Another relative said the family was devastated by the incident. "She had just woken up and was looking for her mother. Within moments, she was gone. No family should have to go through such a tragedy," the relative said. Further investigation is underway. The incident has once again highlighted safety concerns for children living in high-rise residential buildings.

Government to roll out 300 new e-buses on July 4: CM Rekha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday announced that the Delhi Government will roll out 300 new air-conditioned electric buses on July 4, saying the government is fully committed to environment protection and developing a world-class public transport system in the national capital. She also announced that a massive mega-plantation drive to plant 70 lakh saplings across the city will be launched on July 7.

The Chief Minister made the remarks while attending three 'Viksit Bharat Sankalp Sammelan' events held in Pitampura, West Enclave in Shakurbasti, and Mahalaxmi Vihar in Mustafabad to mark 12 years of the Narendra Modi-led Government at the Centre.

At the Pitampura event, the chief minister joined public representatives, party workers and residents



in listening to the Prime Minister's monthly radio programme, Mann Ki Baat. She described the programme as a powerful medium connecting public service with nation-building and said the past 12 years under Modi's leadership represented a "golden era of transformation" for India.

Addressing the gatherings, the Chief Minister credited the Centre with major achievements in sectors such as digital governance, infrastructure, railways, expressways, airports, defence manufacturing and Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT). She said the principle of "Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas,

Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Prayas" remained the guiding force behind development initiatives.

The chief minister said the Delhi Government was implementing key national campaigns, including water conservation through the "Catch the Rain" initiative, promotion of local products under "Vocal for Local", and environmental protection.

She claimed development projects had been expedited across all 70 Assembly constituencies without political discrimination, with work progressing on roads, sewer networks, drinking water supply, schools and hospitals.

Police detain 3,511 in 48-hour crime crackdown, register 106 criminal cases

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central District Police conducted a massive 48-hour intelligence-led enforcement drive under Operation Kavach 14.0, detaining 3,511 people, apprehending 337 offenders and registering more than 100 criminal cases in a sweeping crackdown on narcotics, illegal liquor, arms and gambling.

The operation, carried out between June 22 and June 24 under the direction of police headquarters, involved 99 police teams conducting 338 coordinated raids across crime-prone areas, slum clusters, liquor supply routes and other vulnerable locations.

Deputy Commissioner of Police Rohit Rajbir Singh said the operation reflected the Central District Police's commitment to proactive, intelligence-driven policing aimed at preventing crime, disrupting illegal activities and ensuring public safety across the district. According to police, the operation resulted in the registration of 36 cases under the NDPS Act, 22 under the Delhi Excise Act, 20 under the Arms Act and 28 under the Gambling Act.

As part of the anti-narcotics drive, police arrested 45 people. They seized over 5 kg of ganja, 54.76 grams of smack, and 52 grams of MDMA, along with injectable drugs, syringes, cough syrup bottles and cash suspected to be linked to drug trafficking.

In the campaign against illicit liquor, 22 people were arrested, and 1,530 quarters of



illegal liquor were recovered. Police also arrested 20 people under the Arms Act, recovering two pistols, three country-made firearms (desi kattas), seven live cartridges and 16 knives.

The operation also targeted illegal gambling, leading to the arrest of 59 people. Officers recovered ₹87,050 in cash and seized 1,092 playing cards from the gambling dens. In addition, four alleged auto thieves were arrested, and 10 stolen vehicles were recovered. Police also apprehended four proclaimed offenders during the drive.

Preventive policing formed a major part of the operation, with action taken against hundreds of habitual offenders and violators.

Police verified 306 bad characters/history-sheeters, seized 361 vehicles under the Delhi Police Act, issued 1,119 challans under the Cigarettes and Other Tobacco Products Act (COTPA), and initiated proceedings against several individuals under provisions of the BNSS and the Delhi Excise Act.

One injured after speeding Audi hits SUV, bike in Uttam Nagar area

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A speeding Audi car rammed into an SUV before ploughing into a motorcycle in south-west Delhi's Uttam Nagar area, leaving the motorcyclist seriously injured, police said on Sunday.

The accident took place around 8 pm on Saturday near the fish market in Vikaspuri. According to police, the Audi first struck a Honda Elevate SUV and then hit a motorcycle with great force, causing the rider to suffer serious injuries.

"A PCR call was received at 8.02 pm reporting that a car had hit two vehicles and injured a motorcyclist. Acting on the information, a police team rushed to the spot," a senior police officer said.

When the investigating officer reached the accident site, he found the Audi, the Honda Elevate and the motorcycle lying in a damaged condition.



The injured motorcyclist, 31-year-old Rahul, a resident of Vikas Nagar, had already been admitted to a hospital.

"The teams also recorded the statement of an eyewitness. Based on his account and the preliminary investigation, the (police) team got to know that the Audi was being driven at a very high speed in a rash and negligent manner when the accident occurred," the officer added.

Police have registered an FIR under Sections 281 (rash driving or riding on a public way) and 125(a) (act endangering life or personal safety of others causing hurt) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at Uttam Nagar police station, police said.

Right to walk, but where? Supreme Court ruling shines light on Delhi's footpaths

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Every day in Delhi, thousands of people step off broken pavements, squeeze past rows of parked vehicles, dodge speeding traffic and search for a safe place to cross the road. The everyday struggle came into sharp focus after the Supreme Court declared the right to walk on designated footpaths a fundamental right.

The ruling, delivered by a bench of Justices PS Narasimha and AS Chandurkar in a motor accident compensation case involving the death of a five-year-old boy, held that a citizen's right to walk on des-

ignated footpaths forms part of the freedoms guaranteed under Article 19(1)(d) and the right to life under Article 21 of the Constitution and must take precedence over motor vehicles. Pedestrians have the first claim over footpaths, the court declared.

The judgement has birthed a larger question: In a city where footpaths are frequently occupied, damaged or missing, how much space is really left for pedestrians?

Let's take a look. In Sadar Bazar, Khari Baoli, Naya Bazar, Kashmeri Gate, Mori Gate, Delhi Railway Station, Ajmeri Gate, Dariya Ganj, Ansari Road, Asaf Ali Road, Nai Sadak, markets and footpaths have disappeared. They have

been turned into carts, stalls, tables and parking lots. In some areas, they were broken, blocked, dug up, encroached upon, parked upon or simply interrupted without warning.

In East Delhi's Trilokpuri, heaps of sludge and garbage occupied almost an entire pavement. It appeared to be waste removed from a nearby drain during a cleaning exercise, only to be dumped where pedestrians were expected to walk. A cake furniture vendor had taken over another stretch of the pavement, forcing people onto the carriageway. Mukherjee Nagar, better known as Delhi's coaching capital, presented a different



version of the same problem. Makeshift stalls lined sections of the footpath.

At ITO on the stretch towards the Bar Council of India and other offices, the footpath has been turned into an informal food court.

Carts, stalls, tables, chairs and parked vehicles occupy the pedestrian space.

Between January and March this year, the Delhi Traffic Police issued 4,30,202 on-the-spot challans for improper or obstructive parking, making it

the most common traffic violation in the city, according to official data.

"There is a great deal of inconvenience. The government had earlier spoken about taking action against this issue, but the problem has only become more visible over time. There is simply no space left for people to walk," said Delhi resident Roshan Kumar. Just the other day, Kumar said, he narrowly avoided an accident while walking with his child.

"There is barely any room for pedestrians, and the entire space has been encroached upon. It is difficult for the people to challenge those responsible or even know whom to

approach about the problem," he said.

For Sanjay Kumar, pedestrians bear most of the brunt of this encroachment. "These footpath parking arrangements themselves are problematic. As you can see, a large number of vehicles are parked here, even though there is no legitimate reason for them to occupy the footpath," he said.

"In many areas, you can hardly see the footpath at all," he added. Academic studies paint a similar grim picture.

A study titled 'Perceptions of pedestrian safety in Delhi: a Rasch analysis approach' by the Transportation Research and Injury Prevention Centre at IIT Delhi, conducted in

collaboration with University College London, found that nearly 44 per cent of Delhi's roads do not have footpaths. Researchers surveyed 426 pedestrians across eight wards in south Delhi in 2022, covering roads near metro stations, bus stops and market areas.

The study found that 12 of the 15 conditions used to assess Delhi's pedestrian environment were perceived as unsafe. These included fast-moving traffic, lack of crossings near bus stops, parked vehicles near crossings, two-wheelers and cars on footpaths, poor lighting, absence of CCTV cameras, lack of police presence, and walking after sunset.

Raids uncover theft of devotees’ offerings in Ayodhya temple

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Ayodhya/Lucknow

As dawn broke over the sacred banks of the Sarayu, police teams fanned out across Ayodhya for simultaneous raids on the homes of eight men accused of siphoning donations meant for the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Temple.

Police, along with magistrates, took Aadhaar cards, PAN cards, bank statements, and other documents from the homes of the eight accused men. At one house, they asked family members to unlock the doors. In other homes, they questioned neighbours and relatives about assets and lifestyles that did not match the men's modest salaries.

The eight men, Lavkush Mishra, Anukulp Mishra, Avinash Shukla, Manish Kumar Yadav, Karunesh

Pandey, Ram Shankar Mishra, Subhash Chandra Srivastava, and Ramashankar Yadav (also known as Tinnu), were in charge of counting the cash and valuables donated by thousands of devotees. The raids on June 28 took place two days after a court sent them to judicial custody until June 29.

CCTV footage shows the men taking money several times. Police have found ₹79.85 lakh in cash and some foreign currency with the accused. Earlier, they found bundles of cash hidden under a cow-dung heap at one home and more money in a washroom near the counting room, highlighting the suspected theft.

The case was filed on June 25 under laws related to theft by employees, breach of trust, receiving stolen property, conspiracy, and the Prevention of Corruption Act.



Police officials conduct a search operation at the residence of a relative of Ramashankar alias Tinnu Yadav in Ayodhya on Sunday

PTI

It is based on a report from a three-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) set

up by Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath. After six days of investigation, the team

released its first report on June 23, and a police case was filed based on a complaint

from a trust member.

Investigators found problems in how donations were handled. Rules set in 2025, with help from State Bank of India officials, required security guards during counting, checking staff as they entered and left, conducting random inspections, requiring pocketless uniforms, and retaining CCTV footage for 180 days. These rules were not always followed, which allowed the problems to continue.

In practice, CCTV footage was kept for only about 45 days. Ramashankar Yadav, also known as Tinnu and a former driver for the trust's general secretary Champat Rai, reportedly had keys to several donation boxes, which broke the rules. Subhash Chandra Srivastava, who was in charge of counting donations, got his job through a senior trust official's recommendation. Tinnu

is also said to have helped his relative, Manish Kumar Yadav, join the same team. These failures made it easier for a small group to take money without being noticed right away.

The trust reported an annual income of about ₹327 crore for 2024-25. Most of the accused earned only ₹18,000 to ₹20,000 per month, but investigators are looking into claims that they suddenly bought land and property.

The June 28 raids aimed to uncover these links. Police are collecting documents, family statements, and accounts from neighbours to trace the money. They are also checking if the eight men acted alone or were part of a larger group.

The SIT is reviewing three years of donation records, audits, and cash-counting procedures. It called the

episode “tragic and shameful,” asked why donations from ordinary devotees across India seem to have been stolen, and demanded accountability from trust officials.

The Samajwadi Party has claimed that junior employees are being blamed to protect senior figures. Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath responded firmly: “Tampering with people's faith cannot be tolerated. Whoever tampers with the faith of the people will have to face the consequences.” The state government acted quickly after receiving the SIT report. Still, this situation raises difficult questions that go beyond politics. How did such obvious rule violations continue in a temple watched closely by the public and government? Why did internal audits not catch these problems sooner?

Priyank Kharge vows legal fight, renews demand for RSS registration after Bengaluru court summons

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru



Karnataka Home Minister Priyank Kharge

Karnataka Home Minister Priyank Kharge, facing a defamation case vis-a-vis RSS, on Sunday said the Constitution and law “are on our side,” and that there was nothing to be afraid of.

He said he would fight the criminal defamation case against him through legal means, even as he renewed his demand that the RSS should register itself as an organisation.

His remarks came a day after a Bengaluru court took cognisance of a private complaint alleging that Priyank and former Karnataka Youth Congress president Mohammed Haris Nalapad made defamatory remarks against the RSS, and summoned them to appear before it on July 21.

“We will abide by the law. Our foremost duty is to comply with whatever order the court has issued.

Whatever it may be, we are fighting this through legal means. We did not ask those questions casually or irresponsibly,” the minister told reporters.

Noting that attempts would be made to pressurise them, he said, “All this is natural. They (RSS) will try to exert pressure in every possible way. We will respond to it. When the Constitution and the law are on our side, there is no need to fear anything.”

Citing reported remarks by Vishwaprasanna Tirtha Swami of Pejawar Math, who also had called for the RSS to register itself, Priyank said, “They won't listen to me. They won't listen to you. They won't listen to the Constitution. At least let them listen to the religious leaders.”

Questioning why the RSS had not registered itself, he said, “Once they get registered, the issue will be over. It will put a stop to all those

who go around making statements indiscriminately. Why is the world's largest organisation still not registered?”

He added, “Where are its donations coming from? Who is maintaining the accounts? Who is benefiting from it and who is losing because of it? All of that should become known.”

Backing Priyank, Karnataka Congress president B K Hariprasad said the RSS should first register itself if it welcomed criminal proceedings against the minister.

“Anyone who respects the law of the land - if the RSS is happy that a case has been registered against Priyank, then they must first get their own organisation registered. Double standards will not work,” Hariprasad said.

Stressing that the RSS should function within the framework of the law, he said the Congress and its leaders would present their case in court in the manner they deemed appropriate.

Puri gears up for annual Snan Yatra of Lord Jagannath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Puri

The holy city of Puri is geared up for the Snan Yatra, or the bathing festival, of Lord Jagannath and sibling deities on Monday, with the State Government making all arrangements for the smooth conduct of the pre-Rath Yatra event.

The Snan Yatra day is also considered the birthday of Lord Balabhadra, Devi Subhadra and Lord Jagannath.

The devotees from across the country have started arriving in the pilgrim city to witness the ceremonial 'Pahandi' (procession) of the deities, which is scheduled to be held between 5 am and 7 am.

The deities will be brought to the 'Snan Mandap', a sacred altar on the premises of the 12th-century shrine, where the priests will pour 108 pitchers of water on the idols in full public view.



“The servitors have been requested to complete the rituals as per the schedule, and they have been working with full devotion for the Deva Snan Ustav,” Shree Jagannath Temple Administration (SJTA) chief administrator Arabinda Padhee told reporters.

While the Puri district administration has declared a holiday for the schools in the Puri municipal corporation area, keeping in view the massive congregation of

devotees on the occasion, the police have already deployed 70 platoons (1 platoon comprises 30 personnel) for security, crowd and traffic management.

“The entire city is under CCTV surveillance and stress is being given on crowd management,” Central Range IGP, Satyajit Naik, who has been camping at Puri, said, adding that specialised units, along with several officers, are also deployed for the occasion.

FROM PAGE - 1

India, Seychelles boost ties across 19 sectors

The two countries also signed agreements covering diplomatic training between the Sushma Swaraj Institute of Foreign Service and Seychelles' Ministry of Foreign Affairs and the Diaspora, agricultural research and education, mutual recognition of training and certification of seafarers serving on Seychelles-flagged vessels, and cooperation in the exploration and peaceful uses of outer space. The agreements were announced after delegation-level talks between Prime Minister Modi and President Herminie during the Indian leader's three-day state visit to Seychelles, coinciding with the 50th anniversary of diplomatic relations between the two countries.

Prime Minister Modi is visiting Seychelles at the invitation of President Herminie and will attend the country's National Day celebrations as the Guest of Honour.

West Bengal UCC Bill showdown today

Government sources said officials have spent the past several days studying UCC frameworks adopted in States such as Uttarakhand and examining proposals under consideration elsewhere, while preparing responses to anticipated objections from the Opposition.

Leaders from the other camp have Mamata Banerjee-led TMC camp, which has accused the BJP of using the UCC as an instrument of political polarisation rather than legal reform. For the Ritabrata Banerjee camp, which has sought to establish itself as the State's primary Opposition force, the discussion provides its biggest platform yet to project itself as an effective parliamentary counterweight to the Government.

For the BJP Government, it will be the first major test of its ideological agenda since its electoral victory. For the Opposition, it presents an opportunity to challenge one of the saffron party's signature promises.

And for Bengal's fractured TMC, it offers something else altogether — a chance for two warring factions to fight the same battle separately, each seeking to prove that it is the more effective voice against the State's new rulers.

PM Modi conferred Seychelles’ highest...

Accepting the award, Modi expressed gratitude to the people and Government of Seychelles and dedicated the honour to nations striving to combat climate change.

“Grateful to the people and Government of Seychelles as well as President Herminie for conferring upon me the ‘Guardian of the Blue Horizon,’” Modi said in a post on social media.

“I humbly accept this honour and dedicate it to all those countries that are fighting the challenge of climate change and consider environ-

mental protection their responsibility towards future generations. This is a pressing challenge which we have to overcome together,” he said.

Reaffirming India's commitment to global environmental action, the Prime Minister said the country stands ready to contribute towards building a greener and more sustainable planet. “India is ready to do whatever is required to make our planet greener and sustainable,” Modi said, highlighting the country's domestic and international initiatives, including Mission LiFE, the Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam campaign, the International Solar Alliance (ISA), the Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI) and the International Big Cat Alliance.

In a statement, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said the Presidential Distinction recognises Modi's “leadership and steadfast commitment to environmental conservation, sustainable development, climate resilience, blue economy and advancing the aspirations of the Small Island Developing States.”

The MEA said the honour reflects Seychelles' appreciation of India's expanding role as a trusted partner in capacity building, environmental action and sustainable development across the Indian Ocean Region.

Describing the significance of the award, President Herminie said, “It stands as a symbol of our nation's deepest respect and recognition for those whose leadership and partnership embody the spirit of the guardian of our blue horizon.” The MEA noted that the latest recognition adds to a series of international honours conferred on Modi for his contribution to sustainable development, including the FAO's Agricola Medal, the Seoul Peace Prize and the United Nations' Champion of the Earth Award.

Modi arrived in Seychelles on Saturday for a three-day visit focused on strengthening bilateral ties and enhancing cooperation in maritime security, climate action, development partnership and the blue economy. During the visit, he is scheduled to hold bilateral talks with President Herminie and participate in the country's National Day celebrations.

Earlier this month, the Prime Minister was awarded Slovakia's highest civilian honour, the Order of the White Double Cross (First Class), during his visit to Bratislava.

Ayodhya donation row: Alleged luxury lifestyle...

He built a farmhouse on the village outskirts, an existing vehicle and plans to book a Mahindra Scorpio SUV will come under judicial scrutiny as potential proceeds of crime. The case highlights critical gaps in legal safeguards for managing temple donations. When individuals with family connections secure sensitive roles without rigorous background checks or real-time monitoring, the risk of breach of trust multiplies.

The recoveries and digital evidence now place the onus on the accused to explain the source of their upgraded lifestyles in court. Any failure to account for assets disproportionate to

known income could invite attachment proceedings under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act in addition to the BNS charges.

Legal experts say that swift and transparent prosecution is needed to deliver justice and prevent similar crimes at other religious sites. The current asset investigation and court-supervised trial must ensure clear accountability. If found guilty, Anukulp Mishra and the others could face long jail terms, fines, and loss of property.

The court process should also examine how these appointments were made and whether weak oversight enabled the alleged conspiracy. Restoring public trust needs more than just arrests. It requires digital tracking of donations, independent audits, and stricter legal rules for temple management.

The courts must now make sure that anyone who broke their duty is fully held to account. Only strong legal action can prevent these problems from recurring in places of worship, legal experts say.

India warns against unauthorised...

The MEA also urged prospective pilgrims to exercise caution while selecting private travel agencies. It advised travellers to verify that their chosen tour operator is duly registered and authorised to conduct the pilgrimage.

“Pilgrims are also strongly advised to verify that their tour operator is duly registered and authorised,” the advisory stated.

The warning assumes significance as several private operators advertise Kailash Mansarovar packages through Nepal, often promising expedited arrangements. However, entry into the Tibet Autonomous Region of China requires a valid Chinese visa, a Tibet Travel Permit and other approvals that cannot be guaranteed without prior authorisation from Chinese authorities.

Officials indicated that commencing the journey without confirmed documentation can leave pilgrims stranded in Nepal for extended periods, with limited options for assistance.

The advisory comes just weeks after the annual Kailash Mansarovar Yatra resumed this year. In April, the MEA announced that the pilgrimage would be conducted between June and August through two designated routes: Lipulekh Pass in Uttarakhand, Nathu La Pass in Sikkim

The pilgrimage resumed last year after nearly five years, marking an important step in the gradual normalisation of India-China relations.

The Kailash Mansarovar Yatra is among the most revered religious pilgrimages for Hindus, Buddhists, Jains and followers of the Bon faith. Mount Kailash is regarded as the abode of Lord Shiva in Hinduism, while Lake Mansarovar is considered one of the holiest freshwater lakes in the world. Given that both sites lie within China's Tibet Autonomous Region, Indian pilgrims must obtain multiple clearances before undertaking the journey. The MEA coordinates the official yatra in consultation with Chinese authorities, while many private operators also organise tours

through Nepal, subject to the required approvals.

The latest advisory reflects growing concern over the increasing number of pilgrims facing avoidable difficulties because of incomplete documentation and unverified travel arrangements.

Deadly poison plot foiled at Muharram procession

The plot was exposed after at least one participant, Salman Syed, complained of severe stomach pain and vomiting after consuming a capsule.

Reports indicate several others also fell ill and were rushed to the hospital; all are stated to be out of danger. A medico-legal case was registered. During interrogation, the accused allegedly confessed that he intended to target the procession and claimed he “wanted to kill 15,000 people.” Police have registered a case under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, including provisions for administering poison and attempt to murder. Premji has been sent to police custody. Investigators are now examining his mobile phone, financial transactions, contacts, and travel history. Premji, a BBA graduate, reportedly made multiple trips to Iran and Iraq in recent years, including several in the past year. Police are probing whether he acted alone or was part of a larger network.

The timely intervention by the patrol team averted what officials described as a potential large-scale tragedy during the religious procession. Further investigation is underway to determine the full motive and any possible accomplices. Mumbai Police have hailed the operation as a successful pre-emptive strike that saved countless lives. The seized capsules and remaining poison stock are undergoing forensic examination.

Iran attacks Bahrain, Kuwait after US strikes

The Kuwaiti military said air defences intercepted incoming Iranian drones and missiles on Sunday morning, just after the US strikes.

Kuwait, which hosts a major US army base, said it had detected and intercepted two ballistic missiles, and there were no reports of injuries or damage.

Bahrain's Interior Ministry said the Iranian strikes damaged a residential building near the international airport and no one was killed. The ministry released photos of an 8-story building, with the top floor destroyed, and filled with rubble, and its windows blown out.

The strikes came after the US and Iran traded attacks over the weekend. The US military's Central Command said it struck Iranian military “surveillance infrastructure, communication systems, air defence sites, drone storage facilities and minelay capabilities” on Sunday, following an attack on a ship at sea early Saturday morning. That ship, the Panamanian-flagged tanker Kiku, carried crude oil for the state-run

energy company of Qatar, a key negotiator between Iran and the United States.

In a social media post, Trump said the US had “struck Iranian missile and drone storage locations, and coastal radar sites, for violating the Cease Fire Agreement, AGAIN!” He warned of a point where the US may no longer be able to be reasonable, “and will be forced to militarily complete the job.”

“If that happens, the Islamic Republic of Iran will no longer exist!” Trump wrote on Truth Social.

Damaging Pangong? Ladakh hits tourists...

They said the action follows a series of violations detected by wildlife officials during routine patrolling and through social media surveillance and reported to the LG Secretariat. The violations were reported at four separate locations under the Leh Wildlife Division-Merak and Lukung along the ecologically sensitive shores of Pangong Lake, Nubra Valley. LG Saxena reiterated that while Ladakh warmly welcomes visitors from across the country and the world, tourists must be responsible and environmentally conscious.

He urged tourists, adventure enthusiasts and vehicle owners not to venture into protected wildlife habitats, as such activities disturb endangered species and damage fragile ecosystems and also harm the sanctity of the tourist places.

In the latest incident, the officials said that on June 23, wildlife staff detected a Mahindra Thar (Punjab registration number) being driven off-road near Merak into the waters of the Pangong Lake. The driver had deliberately driven the vehicle into the water for stunt purposes, causing damage to critical wildlife habitat and polluting the lake.

The driver was found prima facie guilty under the Wildlife (Protection) Act, and later, the vehicle was seized.

Similarly, on June 21, wildlife authorities acted swiftly after a video surfaced showing a Hyundai Creta (UP number) engaged in off-road driving near Lukung along Pangong Lake within the Changthang Cold Desert Wildlife Sanctuary. The vehicle was intercepted at Zingral, Changla Pass, and the same day and impounded.

Earlier, on June 20, another social media video revealed a Mahindra Thar (Punjab number) driving through a stream inside the Karakoram (Nubra-Shayok) Wildlife Sanctuary, causing damage to the habitat and ecological integrity of the protected area. Following sustained intelligence gathering through the local police, the vehicle was later intercepted and impounded at Kharu the next day.

Similarly, on June 17, a viral video circulating on social media showed a Toyota Fortuner (Himachal Pradesh number) being driven off-road near Nurbuo La inside the Changthang Cold Desert Wildlife Sanctuary, with the driver reportedly chasing a Tibetan Gazelle.

GRAPEVINE

Mann Ki Baat: PM hails India’s defence self-reliance

Cabinet Secy’s governance philosophy

A recent note by Cabinet Secretary TV Somanathan to Secretaries to the Government of India is far more significant than it may appear at first glance. The accompanying guidance advises officers to question whether a meeting is necessary at all before convening one, to begin meetings on time, keep them focused and preferably within an hour, encourage subordinates to speak freely, even if it means disagreeing with the chair, prepare clear minutes with actionable decisions, and ensure timely follow-up. It also reminds officers that courtesy towards colleagues and external stakeholders is not merely etiquette but an essential leadership trait. Individually, these suggestions appear ordinary. Together, they represent a philosophy of administration.



Calling attention of NDA MPs!

Delhi is buzzing with anticipation after Sunday’s grapevine that BJP-led NDA MPs have been asked to park themselves in the national Capital as talk of a Union Cabinet reshuffle gains momentum. The hopefuls are doing everything they can. MPs are staying up late, calling important contacts, attending the right gatherings, and even looking for astrological signs to boost their chances at a ministerial post. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, known for his political skill, is in control. Will he change his council, bringing in new people and moving others aside to bring fresh energy? Or will he stick with his current team? With rumours spreading from Rashtrapati Bhavan to party offices, everyone in the Capital is waiting to see what he will do. The big question remains: Will Modi make a move or stay the course?



Pehchan Kaun

A top IAS, who served in two crucial ministries of the Government of India, sought early repatriation to his parent State cadre to settle in peace till he retires in February 2029. Grapevine has it that the image of two ministers he served under overshadowed his performance. In the corridors of power, the buzz was that in one of his two postings, which was a sort of public dealing, the minister, as well as subordinates and day-to-day public dealings, was peeved. The Seva Teerth was informed. In the second posting, he felt the heat of the persona of the king-sized Minister. Finally, the bureaucrat sought refuge from his parent cadre and will take charge there shortly.



Govt expands Anaemia Mukht Bharat Abhiyaan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre is overhauling its flagship ‘Anaemia Mukht Bharat (AMB) Abhiyaan’, under which low birth weight (LBW) infants aged 0-6 months will be added as the seventh beneficiary, recognising the importance of addressing anaemia from the earliest stages of life.

Union Health Minister JP Nadda will release the operational guidelines for the revamped strategy at the 16th meeting of the Central Council of Health and Family Welfare (CCHFW) on Monday, introducing a more comprehensive, technology-enabled and community-driven approach, the ministry said in a statement.

The revised guidelines transform the existing Anaemia Mukht Bharat programme into Anaemia Mukht Bharat Abhiyaan, expanding its focus beyond iron supplementation to include early testing, therapeutic management, healthy dietary practices, digital tracking and community participation. A key feature of the new guidelines is the introduction of a 7x7x7 strategy, replacing the earlier 6x6x6 framework.

Under the revised strategy, low birth weight (LBW) babies aged 0-6 months have been added as the seventh beneficiary group, recognising the importance of addressing anaemia from the earliest stages of life, the statement said.

The seventh intervention, titled ‘Eating Right’, seeks to promote regular consumption of iron-rich and diverse diets as a daily habit, and the seventh institutional mechanism introduces a strengthened monitoring and evaluation system supported by digital tracking.

The programme also upgrades its service delivery model from the existing T3 approach ‘Test, Treat and Talk’ to a T4 approach ‘Test, Treat, Talk and Track’.

The revised framework aims to strengthen haemoglobin testing, ensure treatment of iron deficiency anaemia in line with national protocols, improve follow-up and referral through systematic beneficiary tracking, and enhance counselling on nutrition and healthy dietary practices, it said.

For pregnant and lactating women suffering severe



Union Health Minister JP Nadda

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Underlining the country’s march towards self-reliance, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday highlighted several milestones achieved by India, citing the maiden flight of the made-in-India C-295 aircraft and the successful test of the indigenous Long-Range Land-Attack Cruise Missile.

Making this assertion during his monthly radio broadcast ‘Mann Ki Baat’, he also noted that in June itself, the country has achieved a major success in the aviation sector.

Stating that the C-295 aircraft has been made in India, he said, “As many as 40 such aircraft are being built right here in India, and this is giving new strength to MSMEs and the aerospace sector”. It will also increase employment opportunities,

he noted. The first made-in-India C-295 military transport aircraft successfully completed its maiden flight on June 10. The IAF is procuring 56 C-295 transport aircraft at a cost of around Rs 21,935 crore. Forty of these aircraft will be assembled by Tata Advanced Systems Limited in cooperation with Airbus at a production facility in Vadodara.

Modi said in June that the country achieved some other milestones that fill every citizen with pride. “Recently, I got the opportunity to participate in a Navy-related programme in Kolkata. There, INS Dunagiri, INS Shanshak and INS Agrya were inducted into the Indian Navy’s fleet. From the design to the manufacturing of these ships, everything is indigenous,” he said.

The prime minister said in June that the Defence Research and Development



Organisation (DRDO) also successfully tested an indigenous Long-Range Land-Attack Cruise Missile (LRLACM). “In other words, from the seas to the skies, our India is becoming increasingly secure and self-reliant,” he said.

The DRDO on June 15 conducted a successful flight-test of the LRLACM off the

coast of Odisha. The LRLACM is an indigenously built missile with all sub-systems developed by various DRDO laboratories and industry partners.

During the broadcast, Modi also thanked citizens for heeding his appeal to avoid buying gold for some time, holidaying abroad and opting

for carpooling in view of the West Asia situation.

“I am grateful to every citizen of the country; not only have they supported my appeal, but they are also actively cooperating in every way,” he said.

The prime minister said he had also requested farmers to adopt chemical-free farming, protect their farmlands, and maximise the use of natural fertilisers.

Referring to an initiative to prepare the youth for new technology while keeping them rooted in their heritage, he said the Central Sanskrit University in Delhi is launching a B.Tech program in Artificial Intelligence and Data Science. “This marks a crucial step towards integrating modern technology with India’s traditional knowledge,” he said.

Modi said Indian culture is reaching various corners of the globe, noting that in the

Dominican Republic, where the Indian population is just around 100, a team has been formed by some Spanish-speaking locals who have named it ‘Brahmakamal Dominicana.’

“The members study Vedic literature together and are learning to chant Vedic mantras. They have received no formal training on this, but they have learnt the correct pronunciation by listening to audio recordings,” he said.

The prime minister also spoke about the superstition surrounding the Hargila bird in Assam, which plays a vital role in keeping nature clean.

“Hargila was considered inauspicious in certain parts of Assam and trees housing Hargila nests were even cut down,” he said, adding that biologist Purnima Devi Barman witnessed this and resolved to change the misconceptions deeply rooted in people’s minds.

Monsoon 5-6 days away; Delhi, UP reel under intense heat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Conditions are favourable for further advance of the southwest monsoon into several northern states over the next five to six days, the IMD said on Sunday, even as the national Capital recorded its warmest morning in two years amid the delayed seasonal rainfall.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) said in a release that conditions are favourable for further advance of the southwest monsoon into some more parts of the North Arabian Sea and some areas of Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand, among other states, during the next two to three days.

It is likely to continue its movement over some more parts of Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, some areas of



Children play football on a rain-soaked ground during monsoon showers in Mumbai on Tuesday

PTI

Himachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh and southeast Rajasthan during the subsequent two to three days.

However, it also warned of heatwave conditions — possibly severe — in Uttar Pradesh on July 28 and 29.

degrees Celsius, 3.2 notches above the seasonal average, while the maximum climbed to 41.8 degrees Celsius.

The last time the city’s minimum temperature was higher was on June 14, 2024, when it was recorded at 33.3 degrees Celsius.

According to the weather office, a heatwave has been realised over Delhi, and the “feels-like” temperature at 5.30 pm, as calculated by the IMD, was around 50.7 degrees Celsius. For Monday, however, it forecast thunderstorms with rain.

Skymet said the delay in the onset of the monsoon and the interaction of dry and moist winds have kept both temperatures and humidity unusually high.

“Normally, the monsoon reaches Delhi around June 27-28, after which temperatures begin to ease and

humidity increases. This year, however, the monsoon is likely to be delayed by about a week. Dry westerly winds from Pakistan are keeping temperatures high, while south-westerly winds from the Arabian Sea are also reaching Delhi and increasing humidity,” Mahesh Palawat, Vice President (Meteorology and Climate Change), Skymet, said.

“When these dry and moist air masses interact, clouds do form, but there is not enough moisture for widespread rainfall. By the time cloud formation takes place, usually around 4 or 5 pm, the day’s maximum temperature has already been recorded. That is why both the maximum temperature and the ‘feels-like’ temperature have remained unusually high,” he said.

VB-G RAM G Act will burden State finances, says Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Claiming that several States have raised concerns over the MGNREGA-substitute VB G RAM G Act, the Congress on Sunday said the new law would guarantee only centralisation and further financial stress on the States.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said the Modi Government, “vengeful and petty” as ever, bulldozed the repeal of MGNREGA through Parliament without any thorough consultation with the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Rural Development, State Governments, or the other relevant stakeholders.

Now it emerges that several states have raised concerns regarding its substitute, VB G RAM G, scheduled for launch on July 1, Ramesh said on social media.

Even the BJP-governed states such as Madhya Pradesh, Bihar and Uttarakhand have opposed the huge additional expenditure burden that is set to be levied on states once the new law comes into force, he said.

Four other State Governments have opposed the blackout period of the scheme during the peak agricultural season, Ramesh said, adding that at least five states have sought a hike in wages for rural workers.

Even Madhya Pradesh, the home state of the Union rural development minister (Shivraj Singh Chouhan), is voicing concerns around the Modi government’s new pet project, Ramesh alleged.



Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh

“MGNREGA guaranteed right to work derived from the Constitution. VB-G RAM G will guarantee only centralisation and further financial stress on states,” Ramesh said.

The Congress leader also shared a chart on social media that listed the “Modi Government’s four attacks on your right to work”.

It alleged that through the VB G RAM G Act, the Government is “attacking” the right to work, right to fair wages, Panchayati Raj and State finances.

The Congress alleged that the only guarantee the law offers is that of “extreme centralisation” and “weakening of the bargaining power of rural labour”.

The Centre has announced that the Viksit Bharat - Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, or the VB G RAM G Act, will come into force across the country from July 1, replacing the two-decade-old Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA).

Indian Army, Navy to join Seychelles National Day event

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An Indian Army contingent drawn from the Assam Regiment, Navy’s frontline stealth frigate INS Tarkash and indigenously built Survey Vessel Large INS Ikshak are set to take part in the golden jubilee celebrations of the National Day of Seychelles on Monday. Besides, an Indian Navy marching contingent and naval band will also be part of the golden jubilee celebrations of the National Day of the archipelago nation.

The celebrations will be attended by Prime Minister Narendra Modi as the Guest of Honour. Modi is currently on a three-day visit to Seychelles starting June 27, during which he will hold talks with President Patrick Herminie. INS Tarkash, a frontline



warship of the Indian Navy, arrived in Victoria, Seychelles, on June 26 during her ongoing operational deployment to the south-west Indian Ocean Region, the Navy said.

“During the port call, Tarkash, along with #INSIkshak, will participate in

Golden Jubilee celebrations of the National Day of Seychelles, on June 29, with a marching contingent and naval band, India Seychelles #BridgesofFriendship #MAHASAGAR #MaritimeCooperation,” it said in a post on X on Sunday. Indian Navy’s indigenous-

ly built Survey Vessel Large (SVL) — INS Ikshak — has arrived in Victoria as part of her operational deployment to the south-west Indian Ocean Region and to take part in the golden jubilee celebrations of the National Day of Seychelles, a spokesperson of the Indian Navy said on Saturday.

The vessel had arrived at the port of Victoria, Capital of the archipelago nation, on June 26.

An Indian Army official on Sunday said a contingent of the force, comprising 32 personnel from the Assam Regiment and led by Captain Aryan H Deolekar, is set to take part in the celebrations on June 29.

India and Seychelles share long-standing historical ties. Over the years, the relationship has evolved into a strong strategic partnership encom-

passing defence cooperation, development, culture and trade, the Army said.

“An Indian Navy marching contingent accompanied by a military band is also participating in the celebrations, reflecting the close and enduring defence partnership between the two countries,” it said in a statement.

Participation of the Indian armed forces contingents in national celebrations of friendly foreign countries serves as a symbol of mutual trust, military camaraderie and shared commitment towards strengthening bilateral relations, the Indian Army said.

Such engagements reinforce defence cooperation and underscore India’s role as a reliable partner in promoting peace, stability and security in the Indian Ocean Region, it added.

Sonam Wangchuk begins hunger strike at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk on Sunday began a hunger strike at Jantar Mantar, joining the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) protest demanding accountability over alleged irregularities in examinations and seeking the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Before sitting on the fast, Wangchuk, along with CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke, visited Rajghat and paid tribute to Mahatma Gandhi. The protest began with the gathering observing a two-minute silence.

Hundreds of protesters, mostly youth and students, gathered at Jantar Mantar as Wangchuk started his



hunger strike. Several farmer leaders were also present at the protest site.

Explaining his decision to join the protest, Wangchuk said education had been close to his heart for the last 40 years and that he could not remain silent when young people raised concerns over the education system.

“I have been forced to sit here; I am not doing this happily. I am sitting on a fast in support of both issues. Many people ask me, you were doing a movement in Ladakh, why are you with CJP now. Education, which is the issue here, has been close to my heart for the last 40 years, since I was a student,” he said.

States Focus



ARUNACHAL FLOODS: 10 DISTRICTS HIT, DEATH TOLL RISES TO THREE

The toll in the rain-triggered flash flood in Arunachal Pradesh's Keyi Panyor rose to three on Sunday after the body of a man was found in adjoining Papum Pare district, as search and rescue operations were underway, officials said. Floods and landslides caused by incessant rainfall were also reported in several other parts of Arunachal Pradesh, where houses were inundated and infrastructure damaged, prompting the local administrations to launch rescue and evacuation operations, they said. Ten districts – Keyi Panyor, Papum Pare, Kra Daadi, Kurung Kumey, Lower Subansiri, Kamle, Upper Subansiri, East Siang, Leparada and Lower Siang – have been affected by the rain fury, the officials said. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) also forecast the possibility of more than 200 mm of rainfall in parts of Arunachal Pradesh over the next 24 hours till Monday morning.

(PTI)



OVER 46,000 VOTERS REMOVED FROM MIZORAM ELECTORAL ROLLS

More than 46,000 voters have been removed from Mizoram's electoral rolls following the completion of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), a senior official said. The exercise, which began on May 20, concluded on Sunday with all enumeration forms fully digitised, Mizoram Joint Chief Electoral Officer Ethel Rothangpuui told PTI. A total of 46,191 names were deleted from the electoral rolls for reasons including death, untraceable status, permanent migration and duplicate enrolments, she said. Of those removed, 21,290 were deceased, 8,352 could not be traced, 13,992 had permanently shifted to other states or abroad, and 2,245 were found to have duplicate enrolments, she added. Rothangpuui said 312 eligible voters either refused to enrol or re-enrol during the exercise due to religious beliefs. These individuals had either been included in the 2025 electoral rolls or had relatives enrolled during the previous SIR. Following the revision, Mizoram's electorate now stands at 8,28,877, representing 94.72 per cent of the more than 8.75 lakh voters recorded in the 2025 electoral rolls, the official said. The draft electoral rolls will be published on July 4, after which electors can file claims and objections between July 5 and August 4.

(PTI)

MDA website hacked; pro-Pak messages replace homepage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Meerut

The official website of the Meerut Development Authority (MDA) was hacked on Saturday, with unidentified hackers replacing its homepage with a black screen displaying objectionable pro-Pakistan messages and slogans. Visitors attempting to access the site were greeted with the defaced page instead of the usual information on urban development projects, tenders, and civic schemes. Officials confirmed the breach on Sunday and said the MDA's technical and information technology teams have taken the website offline for maintenance. Efforts are underway to restore the portal and secure its servers against further attacks. Superintendent of Police (City) Vinayak Gopal Bhosale said, "The hacking of the Meerut Development Authority's website has come to our notice. The



website is under maintenance for the time being. A case is being registered in connection with the incident, and the matter will be resolved soon." Police have initiated a probe to identify the perpetrators. The case is likely to be registered under relevant sections of the

Information Technology Act. Investigators are examining digital footprints to trace the origin of the attack. The MDA, responsible for planning and development in Meerut and surrounding areas, maintains the website as a key platform for disseminating information to citizens, developers, and con-

tractors. The defacement has raised concerns about the cybersecurity preparedness of Government bodies in Uttar Pradesh. While no data breach or loss of sensitive information has been reported so far, the incident highlights vulnerabilities in official portals. MDA officials are working closely with the police and cyber experts to strengthen security protocols. The website remained inaccessible to the public as of Sunday evening. Authorities have assured that normal services will resume once the portal is fully restored and secured. Similar cyber incidents targeting Government websites have been reported in the past, prompting calls for enhanced digital safeguards. Further details are expected as the investigation progresses. Citizens have been advised to rely on official MDA social media handles and physical offices for information until the website is back online.

Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya opens exhibits on Narasimha Rao, VP Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya inaugurated exhibitions on former Prime Minister PV Narasimha Rao and a unique exhibition as a tribute to former Prime Minister VP Singh, which marks his birth anniversary on July 25. NV Subhash, grandson of the late Narasimha Rao, inaugurated the beginning of a programme to commemorate the 105th birth anniversary of Rao. Nripendra Misra, Chairman of EC, PMML, hosted the Chief Guest in the presence of Priyanka Mishra, CEO, Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya. The exhibition presents a curated collection of rare photographs, official documents, speeches, personal correspondence, and other archival materials that trace Rao's life and public service. Special attention has been given to his leadership during a crucial phase in India's modern history and his pivotal role

in initiating the economic reforms of liberalisation, privatisation and globalisation that reshaped the country's economy. A major highlight of the display is its portrayal of Narasimha Rao as a multifaceted personality – scholar, freedom fighter, reformer and visionary statesman. Audio-visual presentations and selected archival records provide visitors with deeper insight into his contributions to governance, diplomacy, economic transformation and intellectual life. Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya said the exhibition aims to celebrate the enduring legacy of the leader commonly regarded as an architect of modern, globalised India, and to foster greater awareness of his contributions among students, researchers and the general public. The exhibition on VP Singh traced his journey from his early life to becoming the Prime Minister of India through archival documents, rare photographs, and newspaper clippings. It also showcased a selection



of poems written by VP Singh, offering visitors an insight into his literary contributions alongside his political legacy. A special highlight of the exhibition was the display of 19 original paintings created by Singh. "On the eve of the 105th birth anniversary of the late PV Narasimha Rao, Bharat Ratna awardee and former Prime Minister of India, I feel honoured and privileged to be here at the Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya. Narasimha Rao was a great scholar, statesman, and politician – the first South Indian to become Prime Minister. A multilingual leader, he always placed the nation first, the party next, the family after, and himself last. Rare are such leaders who consistently think of the people. This photo exhibition will inspire the youth, showing how an ordinary person from a poor family in a remote village could rise to become Prime Minister through sheer hard work and vision for the country," said NV Subash, who is a BJP leader.

Mamata camp files police complaints against Ritabrata faction

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The battle for control of the TMC spilt further onto the legal turf on Sunday, with the Mamata Banerjee-led faction lodging fresh police complaints against dissident leader Ritabrata Banerjee and his associates, accusing them of illegally using the party's name, symbol and organisational designations to mislead workers and supporters. The complaints, filed by TMC's joint national secretary Dola Sen, came a day after the party's 'Kalighat wing' had approached the Pragati Maidan and New Town police with similar allegations against the breakaway camp. The move marks a sharp escalation in the month-long struggle within the party following the Assembly poll debacle, with both camps now increasingly relying on legal and organisational measures to establish their claim over the party's legacy and structure. In the latest complaints at



TMC's joint national secretary Dola Sen

Kalighat police station and Kolkata Police's Cyber Crime Division, the Mamata Banerjee loyalists named Ritabrata Banerjee, former minister Arup Roy, Javed Khan, Sandipan Saha and Biplab Mitra, alleging that they were attempting to run a parallel organisation by projecting themselves as office-bearers of the All India Trinamool Congress without authorisation from the party leadership. "The accused persons are using the party's name, symbol and organisational

positions to create confusion among workers and supporters and damage the party's image," the complaint alleged. The police complaints come less than a week after the rebel faction organised a high-profile "special session" at a luxury hotel in New Town, where it announced a new national working committee that excluded both Mamata Banerjee and her nephew Abhishek Banerjee. The June 22 meeting, attended by several MLAs and former legislators, was

projected by the dissidents as an attempt to "rebuild" the organisation after the party's crushing defeat in the assembly elections. On Saturday, the Ritabrata camp held another gathering in east Kolkata's Topsis area, drawing 47 former Kolkata Municipal Corporation councillors, which political observers viewed as a concerted effort to strengthen its urban support base ahead of the civic polls likely later this year. Notably, banners and signage at both meetings prominently displayed the TMC's grass-and-twin-flower symbol and the party's official name, even as portraits of Mamata Banerjee – once the unquestioned face of the organisation – were absent. In its complaint at the New Town police station, the Mamata Banerjee camp sought an investigation into those allegedly operating behind the scenes of the dissident movement, and questioned the source of funds being used for organ-

ising meetings, printing publicity material and running social media campaigns in the party's name. The loyalist faction also challenged the validity of positions claimed by rebel leaders. It cited a recent communication by Ritabrata Banerjee to Assembly Speaker Rathindra Bose in which he described himself as the party's "general secretary", a designation which, according to the Mamata Banerjee camp, has never been conferred upon him by the organisation. Another complaint referred to a meeting convened for Kolkata's TMC councillors by leaders of the breakaway faction, alleging that invitations were issued under unauthorised party designations. Ritabrata Banerjee, however, has dismissed the allegations. "Anyone can file a complaint. There is law in the country, and there is the Election Commission. Let there be faith in the law and the ECI," he said.

PMK urges Tamil Nadu Govt to break its silence on VB-G RAM G

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

PMK leader Anbumani Ramadoss on Sunday urged the Tamil Nadu Government to 'break its silence' on the new rural employment scheme of the Centre – VB-G RAM G – that replaced the UPA-era MGNREGA and clarify whether it intends to implement it. "Only days are left before July 1, the date on which VB-G RAM G has to be implemented. Only 19 states/UTs have issued notifications to this effect so far. As Tamil Nadu has not made any official announcement regarding its stance, crucial questions have arisen over whether rural labourers in the state will receive employment under this new framework", he said in a statement here. Stating that the Union



PMK leader Anbumani Ramadoss

Government has introduced sweeping modifications to the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA), which previously guaranteed 100 days of work, he said, "The new 125-day employment program is scheduled to come into effect from July one." "Out of the ₹95,692 crore allocated across the country for this scheme, Tamil Nadu has been earmarked ₹7,957.57 crore," he said.

Deendayal Port sets national cargo record in 24 hours

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhuj

Deendayal Port Authority (DPA), Kandla has achieved a new national milestone by handling 7.78 lakh tonnes of cargo within 24 hours, marking the highest single-day cargo movement recorded at any major Government port in India. According to port authorities, the record was achieved on June 26 through the efficient handling of a wide range of import and export cargo across multiple vessels. The performance highlights the port's growing operational strength and its ability to manage high cargo volumes with speed and precision. Officials attributed the achievement to coordinated efforts by port management, employees, dock workers, shipping agents, stevedores and transport operators. Investments in modern cargo-handling equipment, digital monitoring systems and logistics infrastructure have also played a significant role in enhancing efficiency. Already among India's leading ports in annual cargo throughput, Deendayal Port's latest accomplishment further reinforces its position as a key maritime gateway on the country's western coast. Industry observers believe the record reflects the continuing expansion of India's port infrastructure and logistics capabilities, while boosting confidence among exporters and importers.



PDP sparks backdoor job row; Omar Abdullah's Government hits back

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Sharpening its attack on the issue of 'back door appointments' by the Omar Abdullah-led Government, a People's Democratic Party (PDP) Young Turk, Iltija Mufti, went public on Sunday with a list of companies engaged in a recruitment drive. In response, the Omar Abdullah-led Government swiftly deployed three top guns to clear the air. Earlier, People's Democratic Party (PDP) Chief Mehbooba Mufti alleged that 25000 'backdoor appointments' have been made by the current dispensation in the Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir. In her social media post on X, Iltija Mufti Sunday posed some direct



PDP leader Iltija Mufti

questions to know why hundreds of crores are being spent on outsourcing jobs to private companies. Who selected these companies, and what was the selection process? On what basis are

people being recruited without a transparent merit-based process? Will the Government make these contracts and recruitment details public? Reacting to these allegations, Nasir

Aslam Wani, Advisor to the Chief Minister, along with two senior Cabinet ministers, Sakina Itoo and Javid Ahmad Dar, on Sunday clarified that the outsourcing system at the centre of the controversy was not of their making, and dared their critics to prove otherwise. Addressing a hurriedly called Press Conference in Srinagar, Nasir Aslam Wani explained, "Many misconceptions have been spread regarding our Government's employment policy". "It is our duty to clear these misunderstandings because it is our responsibility to ensure that the public receives the correct facts." Comparing the working of the two successive Governments, Wani claimed,

"Today, we are not witnessing the practices that were common in the past – paper leaks, cancelled selection lists, and other irregularities". "Those experiences belong to the past." The Omar Abdullah-led Government, he said, had launched a mission to fill nearly 40,000 vacancies through a transparent, merit-based process and expected it to be completed soon. Specifically on the outsourcing controversy, Wani cornered the previous PDP administration. "Just as they left us with the consequences of the abrogation of Article 370, the loss of statehood, the division of the erstwhile state into three parts," he said, "they also left behind this outsourcing

system." He added that the entire outsourcing framework had been put in place between 2015 and 2018, and that all appointments now being questioned were initiated before the 2024 elections. "The same process has simply continued." Wani then issued a direct challenge to critics: "If anyone can produce even a single piece of evidence proving that this Government has made a backdoor appointment, let them do so." Referring to the allegations of back-door appointments, Cabinet minister Sakina Itoo sought to explain the operational rationale for outsourcing, describing it as a short-term administrative necessity rather than a recruitment channel. "Outsourced person-

nel are engaged over and above the sanctioned strength of any department," she said, offering the example of a hospital that installs an extra X-ray machine but needs a technician immediately. "Patients cannot be made to wait indefinitely while the formal recruitment process takes place. "Itoo also clarified the procurement process for outsourcing agencies. "These outsourcing agencies are selected through the Government e-Marketplace portal using a transparent tendering process," she said, adding that renewals and extensions were merely a continuation of policy inherited from the previous Government.

Govt proposes amendments to Medical Devices Rules

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Union Health Ministry has proposed amendments to the Medical Devices Rules, 2017, to shorten the timelines for the grant of manufacturing licences for medical devices across different risk categories. The draft notification, published in the official gazette, seeks to simplify and expedite the licensing process while ensuring continued compliance with quality, safety and performance requirements, the ministry said on Sunday.

The proposed amendments seek to rationalise the timelines for the grant of manufacturing licences for medical devices across different risk categories. The initiative is aimed at enhancing the ease of doing business, improving regulatory efficiency, and facilitating the



Representative photo

timely availability of quality medical devices in the country, the ministry said.

Under the Medical Devices Rules, 2017, medical devices are classified into four risk-based categories — Class A, Class B, Class C and Class D — with Class D comprising the highest-risk devices.

The rules prescribe statutory timelines for processing applications for manufacturing licences for each category. The proposed amendments seek to reduce these

timelines, thereby enabling faster regulatory approvals while maintaining the established standards of quality, safety and performance.

For Class B medical devices, which include low to moderate risk devices such as blood pressure monitors, hypodermic needles and pulse oximeters, the timeline for grant of manufacturing licence has been proposed to be reduced from 140 days to 115 days. Similarly, for Class C and Class D medical devices, which

include high-risk devices such as cardiac stents, hip and knee implants, and other orthopaedic implants, the timeline for the grant of a manufacturing licence has been proposed to be reduced from 105 days to 90 days.

The draft amendments also introduce clearly defined timelines for each stage of the licensing process, including scrutiny of applications, audit by notified bodies, verification of compliance and issuance of licences.

This is expected to bring greater transparency, predictability and efficiency to the regulatory framework, benefiting both the medical device industry and patients through faster access to quality-assured medical devices, the ministry said. The draft notification has been placed in the public domain for comments and suggestions from all stakeholders.

Kuki-Zo body urges removal of highway blockades in Manipur



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kangpokpi

A Kuki-Zo organisation in Manipur's Kangpokpi urged the Central and State Governments to remove all blockades, allegedly by Naga groups, along the national and State highways passing through the district.

The Committee on Tribal Unity (CoTU) said that following joint deliberation with all civil society organisations (CSOs) of Kangpokpi, it unanimously resolved to "serve a 48-hour ultimatum", effective from Sunday midnight, for removing all blockades.

The development came in the wake of price rise and depleting stocks of essential commodities in the Kuki-Zo majority district, caused by the blockades on NH-2 and NH-37, sources said. CoTU said road transportation, the "lifeline of the people and backbone of economic activities", has remained severely disrupted for over a month due to blockades and unauthorised checkpoints allegedly manned by Naga groups.

Pune realtor murder: Police use dummy to recreate crime scene

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Pune

Police on Sunday took Siya Goyal, an accused in the alleged murder of her fiancé and Pune realtor Ketan Agarwal, to Lohagad Fort to reconstruct the crime scene, using a dummy to recreate the moment he was pushed to his death, an official said.

The exercise was aimed at establishing the exact chain of events of the June 18 incident, when the 25-year-old victim was allegedly killed by Goyal (20) and her 'lover', Chetan Chaudhary (22), he said.

"A crime scene recreation was conducted this morning. The accused was taken to the actual spot where the incident took place," a senior official from the Pune rural police said. He said that a dummy body was created, and police officials asked Goyal to demonstrate how she pushed Ketan from the location. She also showed the route taken to reach the crime spot. Chaudhary would be taken to the fort separately for a similar reconstruction, he added. Goyal and



Chaudhary have been arrested for allegedly conspiring to kill Agarwal and pushing him off Lohagad Fort in Pune district.

Goyal has allegedly told police that she did not want to marry Agarwal, and hence plotted with Chaudhary to kill him as she thought calling off the wedding would bring disrepute to the family.

Investigators are probing various aspects of the case, including the planning of the alleged crime, the movements of the accused before and after the incident, their digital footprint, and the motive behind the murder, a senior police official said.

Row over MP minister's remark on officials rushing to RSS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

Madhya Pradesh minister Kailash Vijayvargiya's alleged remark that administrative officials in the State have been rushing to show their affiliation with the RSS after the BJP came to power has triggered a row, with the Congress terming it a threat to the neutrality of the bureaucracy.

Addressing a memorial event for a former RSS pracharak on Friday, Vijayvargiya claimed that since the BJP came to power, there has been a "race" among officials to show their affiliation to the RSS, adding that the organisation has



Kailash Vijayvargiya

become "too crowded" with a shortage of "good people."

The videos of the minister's comments are now circulating on social media, drawing fire from the Opposition. In one such clip,

Vijayvargiya is heard recounting his interactions with an official.

"When we were in the Government, some officer came and said, 'Sir, I used to go to the shakha.' Hey, you go now... You never told me before our Government came to power," he said. The senior BJP leader claimed that every officer has a desire to show off his affiliation with the Sangh. "Every officer and employee thinks this... After the Government came to power, everyone became part of the RSS. Every officer became part of the RSS," he is heard saying in one of the videos. He narrated that one

such officer told him that his father was the president of an RSS shakha, even though there is no such position in the organisation.

Vijayvargiya also lamented that the organisation lacked good people. Referring to the late Sangh pracharak Shaligram Tomar and some other RSS officials from Madhya Pradesh, he said, "Such people are rare.

The organisation is growing, and its ideology is also growing, so to speak. But if there are no good people, then we should reflect and ponder over the importance of that ideology."

Sharing a video of the minister's

statement on X, Madhya Pradesh Congress Committee President Jitu Patwari said that Vijayvargiya's public statement raises a serious Constitutional question.

"If this type of identification has increased in the administrative system, then it is not just a political comment, but a deep and serious issue related to the fairness, neutrality, and constitutional dignity of the Indian administrative system!" he wrote in his post.

Patwari stated that the Constitution of India requires every Government official to be loyal to it and not to any political or ideological organisation.

Uddhav demands disqualification of 6 rebel MPs



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Parbhani

Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray on Sunday demanded the immediate disqualification of six party MPs who recently defected to the Eknath Shinde-led camp, alleging that their switch was part of a larger political conspiracy.

Addressing a rally in Parbhani, the former Maharashtra chief minister said the Lok Sabha Speaker must uphold the rule of law regarding the defections and alleged that the BJP's central leadership was systematically "clipping the wings" of its own state leaders. He attacked the BJP over the Ram Mandir donation embezzlement issue, accusing the saffron party of exploiting the temple for political gain, labelling it the "Babur Janata Party".

"Babur demolished the Ram Mandir. A 'Babur Janata Party' has now come to loot the newly constructed temple. What is the difference between them?" he questioned.

Thackeray stated that MPs loyal to the Shiv Sena (UBT) had submitted a formal representation to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla seeking an opportunity to present their side, noting that party MP Arvind Sawant had cut short an official visit to Kargil after the Speaker advanced the date of the hearing.

"If there is a rule of law in this country, these six MPs should be disqualified. I still believe in the Lok Sabha Speaker because if he does not follow the law, he cannot ask others to follow it.

All Sikh MLAs, ministers to appear before Akal Takht, says Punjab CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

All Sikh MLAs and cabinet ministers will appear before the Akal Takht, which summoned them on June 29 regarding the anti-sacrilege law, Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann said on Sunday.

His statement came after a closed-door meeting with the party MLAs in Amritsar to decide the course of action in view of the directions of the Akal Takht, the highest temporal seat of Sikhs. Our MLAs and ministers will go there and present their sides in writing, Mann said while speaking to reporters in Amritsar.

Akal Takht Jathedar Giani Kuldip Singh Gargaji, on June 15, had summoned all Sikh MLAs, regardless of party affiliation, and the Sikh ministers before the Akal Takht on June 29 regarding the anti-sacrilege law.

Non-Sikh Cabinet ministers have been asked to submit their views in writing on the matter before 29 June.

The Akal Takht and the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) had raised objections to the anti-sacrilege law — Jaagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Act, 2026 — saying it was enacted without consulting the Sikh Panth.

The Akal Takht had earlier asked the State Government to remove provisions from the anti-sacrilege Act which are "against the Guru Granth Sahib, the Khalsa Panth and the sentiments of the 'Sangat' (Sikh community)."

Already, Sikh MLAs of other parties have confirmed that they would appear before the Akal Takht.

Replying to a question whether he will appear before the Akal Takht, the chief minister said he has not been summoned.

"Our MLAs and Cabinet ministers will present the Government side. Punjab Assembly Speaker (Kulraj Singh Sandhwan) will also go. Whatever suggestions come from the Akal Takht or SGPC, we will discuss the same," said Mann, who was accompanied by AAP supremo Arvind Kejriwal.

Replying to another question over a purported video, Mann said he will send the clip, in which a person could be seen wearing a mask resembling his, to the Akal Takht.

Mann said he will also present his side in writing to the highest temporal seat of Sikhs, mentioning that a fake video has been made by putting a mask on someone. Stating that the



AAP National Convenor Arvind Kejriwal and Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann during a press conference in Amritsar on Sunday

Akal Takht Sahib is above everything, he said his reverence for it is evident from the fact that when he was earlier summoned, he even skipped a function of the President of India to appear before it.

Replying to a question that the Opposition parties are accusing him of challenging the authority of the Akal Takht, Mann said, "I could not even think of doing it."

However, when political appointees occupying religious positions start taking one-sided decisions to appease their political masters, questions naturally arise, he said.

Mann said hoardings are being put up outside gurdwaras "to make the people aware about the order issued by the Akal Takht Sahib".

He questioned why similar boards were not installed against Akali Dal leader Sukhbir Singh Badal when he was declared "tankhaiya" (guilty of religious misconduct).

Hoardings calling for his social boycott are being installed outside gurdwaras at many places by the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee.

Mann accused the Congress, Akalis and the BJP of joining hands to target him for political gains by trying to give a religious colour to the issue.

Replying to a question on the SGPC deciding to hold a gathering on July 5 to spread awareness among Sikh congregations regarding the Sri Akal Takht Sahib's directives, Mann said it can do so at any time.

To a question regarding the Maharashtra Government's recent decision to repeal the 70-year-old Nanded Sikh Gurdwara Sachkhand Sri Hazur Abchalnagar Sahib Act, 1956, Mann said it should not interfere in the affairs of the Sikh community.

Meanwhile, Arvind Kejriwal said, "The BJP Government in Maharashtra should refrain from hurting the sentiments of Sikhs through such actions, which are not in the interest of anyone. Politics and religion are separate, and they should never be mixed under any circumstances," he said.

He said a grand temple dedicated to Luv, Kush and Mata Janaki will be built next to the temple of Lord Valmiki in Amritsar. Regarding the alleged embezzlement of devotees' offerings at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, Kejriwal claimed that the main persons facing the maximum accusations are roaming freely. He further said police did not seek remand of those arrested in the case for questioning and demanded a probe to find where the money has gone.

Mock rescue drills held along Amarnath yatra routes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar/Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Police on Sunday conducted comprehensive high-altitude operational drills at 18 strategic locations — many of them snow-bound — along the twin routes to the cave shrine of Amarnath, to assess the preparedness of its mountain rescue teams (MRTs), an official said.

To bolster safety measures for the pilgrimage, 45 specialised MRTs, comprising personnel from the Jammu and Kashmir Police, National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), State Disaster



Response Force (SDRF) and Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), have been deployed along the 48-km Pahalgam route in Anantnag district and the 14-km Baltal route in Ganderbal district, the official

said. The annual 57-day yatra to the cave shrine, situated at an altitude of 3,880 metres in the south Kashmir Himalayas, is scheduled to commence on the twin routes on July 3.

Simultaneous mock rescue

drills were conducted at all the strategic locations, many of them still snow-bound, to assess the preparedness of the MRTs for ensuring the security of pilgrims, and timely response in cases of emergency, Ram Singh — who is overseeing the 18 rescue teams along the yatra routes — said.

He said the exercise involved MRTs deployed at Chandanwari, Pissu Top, Zojibal, Nagakoti, Wavbal, MG Top, Poshpathri, Kelnar, Dardkote, Sangam Top, Holy Cave, Lower Holy Cave, Y-Junction, Brarimarg, Railpathri, Domail, Panjarni and Sheshnag.

Rajasthan launches mental health programme in 1,500 schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

Rajasthan has introduced a structured mental health and well-being programme in primary education with the launch of the 'Khushishala' initiative in around 1,500 Government schools.

Officials claimed that Rajasthan is the first State in the country to launch such a programme.

The programme, implemented by the Rajasthan State Council of Educational Research and Training (RSCERT), targets students from Classes 1 to 5 and focuses on their emotional



Representative photo

well-being, social development and life skills through activity-based learning.

RSCERT Director Shweta Fagediya said the initiative also includes mental health and capacity-building training for teachers, enabling them to better understand and address the children's emotional needs.

"Khushishala has made Rajasthan the first State in India to implement a mental health and well-being programme at the primary education level. The objective is to strengthen children's emotional resilience and social-emotional skills while equipping teachers to better under-

stand and support students' emotional needs," she said.

Under the programme, teachers undergo a three-day training module along with a 21-day audio-based course focusing on emotional awareness, stress recognition, relationship building and well-being. Special teacher handbooks and mobile-based resources have also been developed to facilitate classroom activities.

She said the programme goes beyond teacher training and focuses on helping educators effectively translate well-being concepts into age-appropriate classroom activities. According to

education experts, teacher-led wellbeing programmes can improve classroom participation, social interaction and students' ability to cope with challenges. Such interventions also help teachers identify and respond to the children's emotional needs more effectively.

"The pilot involved 120 teachers and recorded a 53 per cent improvement in socio-emotional skills among students. Among girls, the improvement reached 69 per cent. The findings also indicated stronger teacher-student relationships and greater emotional development among children," she said.



Editor's
TAKE

Friendship renewed, strategy deepened

Modi's visit to Seychelles reaffirms India's resolve to anchor itself as Seychelles' trusted partner in the Indian Ocean

Seychelles marked fifty years of independence even as both nations marked fifty years of diplomatic relations established in 1976. Modi's last visit, in 2015, had set the template for India's outreach to Indian Ocean island states; this return – only the second by an Indian prime minister since 1981 – signalled that it has moved from a foreign-policy footnote to a recurring engagement, even if the eleven-year gap leaves room for more frequent high-level contact going forward.

The highlights were unusually rich for a National Day visit. Modi stood as Guest of Honour at the Golden Jubilee parade, where an Indian Armed Forces contingent marched alongside Seychellois troops and two Indian Navy warships anchored offshore – a quiet but pointed reminder of Delhi's naval reach. More significant was the substance behind the ceremony: Modi became the first Indian prime minister to address Seychelles' National Assembly, a gesture that elevated a transactional partnership into something closer to a parliamentary kinship between the world's largest democracy and one of the Indian Ocean's smallest.

Modi handed over the Made-in-India fast patrol vessel PS Lespwar to the Seychelles Coast Guard, along with ambulances, utility vehicles and laser radial boats meant to strengthen surveillance of an exclusive economic zone roughly 1.3 million square kilometres in size. This builds on years of quieter support – Dornier surveillance aircraft, a coastal radar network – and points to a partnership measured less in declarations than in delivered capability, an increasingly important currency in a region where promises often outpace performance.The real architecture, though, was laid earlier this year.

President Herminie's February state visit to India produced the SESEL Joint Vision framework, seven memoranda covering maritime security, digital cooperation, the blue economy and education, and a \$175 million package – a \$125 million rupee line of credit plus \$50 million in grants. This visit was less about fresh announcements than about reviewing implementation: a Seychelles Hydrographic Unit taking shape with Indian assistance, and a planned joint hydrography consultation later this year, suggest the relationship is shifting from pledges to project management.Strategically, the visit fits within Vision MAHASAGAR, India's evolving Indian Ocean doctrine, which treats Seychelles as a sentinel guarding sea lanes connecting the Gulf, East Africa and South Asia. That the visit overlapped with Seychelles' own commemorations of fifty years of ties with China is a useful reminder: India's edge will rest on consistency and follow-through rather than sentiment alone.

Ceremony aside, is this: the visit's true worth will be judged by whether the hydrographic unit, the credit line and the promised joint exercises actually materialise. For Seychelles, India offers an unusually equal partnership for an island nation of barely 120,000 people. For India, sustaining that goodwill is the price of credibility as an Indian Ocean power. Fifty years on, the relationship has matured past symbolism – what it needs now is patient, unglamorous follow-through.

Leaders come and go, institutions endure

Frequent changes at the top undoubtedly create uncertainty and can complicate long-term policymaking. But they may also reflect a political system in which leaders remain answerable to Parliament and their own party rather than insulated by fixed terms or personal mandates



BHOPINDER SINGH

Six Prime Ministers of the United Kingdom have left office in the last ten years (2016-2026). Only one-Rishi Sunak-departed as a result of electoral defeat. The other five-David Cameron, Theresa May, Boris Johnson, Liz Truss, and now Keir Starmer-left office primarily due to internal party pressure, perceived failure to deliver, or loss of parliamentary confidence. Many observers have prematurely interpreted this phenomenon-the "revolving door" at 10 Downing Street-as evidence of institutional decline or systemic instability within British democracy. But does such turnover necessarily produce persistent policy paralysis? Does it automatically indicate weak leadership legitimacy or strategic drift?

While frequent leadership change can certainly create short-term uncertainty, policy discontinuity, and even public fatigue, it would be an overstatement to assume that the United Kingdom is uniquely unstable in this respect. Other advanced parliamentary democracies with similarly episodic leadership turnover-such as Japan, Australia, and Belgium-have not experienced existential threats to democratic continuity or governance itself. Conversely, countries with comparatively stable leadership tenures can still suffer democratic erosion if the institutions responsible for scrutinising executive power weaken over time. Stability in leadership, therefore, is not synonymous with democratic health.

An alternative interpretation is that frequent leadership change may reflect a form of internal democratic responsiveness rather than systemic breakdown. In the UK context, it can be seen as an expression of robust parliamentary control over the executive. Leaders can be removed swiftly when they lose the confidence of their party or Parliament, allowing for rapid correction of perceived governance failures. This mechanism avoids prolonged dysfunction and reduces the risk of entrenched ineffective leadership. Unlike systems where leadership change requires fixed electoral cycles or extraordinary constitutional procedures, the Westminster model enables relatively immediate adjustment when political consensus collapses.

Crucially, this form of accountability can remove failing leadership without destabilising the state itself. It does not require constitutional rupture, military intervention, or prolonged administrative paralysis. Instead, it operates through established parliamentary conventions, preserving continuity in governance even as individuals at the top change. In this sense, accountability becomes real-time rather than episodic, discouraging complacency and reinforcing per-



formance-based legitimacy.

Moreover, the British political system structurally discourages long-standing personality cults and hereditary political dominance. Leadership is not derived from personal mandate alone but is continuously contingent on parliamentary support. While charismatic leaders certainly exist, their authority remains institutionally constrained. The electorate chooses a Parliament, not a Prime Minister, and the Prime Minister serves only so long as they command the confidence of the House of Commons. This principle is often summarised in the constitutional logic that the executive is accountable to the legislature rather than directly insulated by a fixed term.

As Winston Churchill famously observed, "The Prime Minister is the servant, not the master, of the House of Commons." This principle is not merely rhetorical; it is embedded in the operational logic of the system. Churchill himself became Prime Minister in 1940 without a general election following the resignation of Neville Chamberlain, and he later made way for Anthony Eden in 1955, again without a direct electoral contest for the premiership. These transitions established a core tenet of Westminster governance: leadership may change when parliamentary confidence shifts, but the continuity of the state remains intact, and electoral legitimacy resides in the legislature rather than the individual officeholder.

Within this framework, leadership transitions are often treated as constitutional normality rather than political rupture. This helps explain why figures such as Keir Starmer could frame resignation as an acceptance of parliamentary judgment rather than a personal or ideological defeat. As he noted in his resignation speech: "My party has asked whether I am best placed to lead us into the next general election. I have heard the answer of my parliamentary party to that question, and I accept that answer with good grace." This reflects a political culture

in which leadership change is institutionalised rather than personalised, and where resignation is often interpreted as procedural rather than adversarial. Similarly, the post-office trajectories of former prime ministers illustrate a relatively non-confrontational political culture. David Cameron briefly returned as Foreign Secretary under Rishi Sunak. Theresa May now serves in the House of Lords as a senior stateswoman. Boris Johnson remains an active public commentator. Liz Truss participates in political discourse outside formal office. Rishi Sunak continues as a Member of Parliament while engaging in private-sector advisory roles. While disagreements certainly persist, there is comparatively limited evidence of prolonged factional rupture or personalised political vendettas following departure from office.

However, frequent turnover is not without cost. Repeated leadership changes can lead to policy inconsistency, disruption in long-term planning, and uncertainty among international partners and domestic stakeholders. Governments are ultimately responsible for decisions, and effective decision-making often requires continuity, coherence, and time. Excessive volatility at the top may therefore undermine strategic clarity, even if institutional stability remains intact.

At the same time, there is a countervailing temptation to prioritise continuity at the expense of responsiveness, potentially weakening democratic accountability. The challenge lies in balancing stability with adaptability. As Churchill also famously remarked, "Democracy is the worst form of Government except for all those other forms that have been tried from time to time." This acknowledgment captures the inherent imperfections of democratic systems, including those that permit frequent leadership turnover.

Ultimately, the experience of the "revolving door" at 10 Downing Street underscores a fundamental feature of the Westminster system: leaders are temporary, but institutions endure.

The writer is a former Lieutenant Governor of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Puducherry, and a military veteran;

The child behind the disability

schools, work places and public institutions to help support individuals to participate fully in everyday life. Parents and children are less embarrassed and more willing to discuss it openly. The stigma that was once attached to these disabilities has now gradually diminished. A person with physical impairments, mobility challenges and facial differences are easier to spot and easy for us to offer assistance. They receive special services in their daily living, for example at airports, public parking, public facilities, workplaces, etc. However, disabilities such as Autism, ADHD, OCD, learning disabilities and anxiety disorders are less apparent, hence easily overlooked. They do not receive the same immediate attention and treatment. It is only when one interacts with such individuals and their families that one becomes familiar with their daily challenges.

I remember a conference with a parent who was concerned as to how their son would cope with school. Although there was no formal diagnosis made, doctors suspected he might have autism and might face challenges in life, but it was too early to know for certain.

My heart went out to them when I saw tears in their eyes. The fear of uncertainty was overwhelming and devastating for them. I assured them that every effort would be made to accommodate their son's needs and for him to be included in a regular classroom setting.

Schools usually conduct their own evaluation, observe them in a classroom setting and then chalk out an individualised education plan that meets the needs of that individual. Teachers work closely with parents and the infor-

mation and documents are available only to staff members who work directly with the student. The parents left that meeting feeling hopeful and reassured. Since then, I have participated in many such conferences. Each of these meetings has reminded me that not everything can be learned in classrooms or in textbooks. The gratitude and trust shown by these families has been immensely rewarding and the understanding that empathy and compassion go a long way. Fortunately, there has been tremendous technological advancement in determining the early onset and continued support for individuals who cannot walk, talk or see. to be included in society. There are advanced wheelchairs, voice activated devices, sign language, hearing aids, braille technology and software have opened doors that were not possible in the past. For conditions like, Autism, ADHD, Down syndrome, Dyslexia, Cerebral Palsy, and OCD there is early diagnosis and new medications, counseling services, continued research, grants, technological advancements, media and general awareness in society are more prevalent than a decade ago.After all these years I have come to realise that when people are different and don't fit in a box of normalcy or within the normal spectrum, we view them with sympathy. While knowledge makes us understand the disability, it is compassion and empathy that helps us understand the child.

The writer is an educator based in the US and the author of several children's books

PIC TALK



A man and a monkey rest side by side on a hot summer day, in Kolkata.

PHOTO: PTI



SHARMILA VAIDYA

2ND OPINION

As an educator for over 26 years, I have worn many different hats. I have worked with children, both with and without disabilities, conducted assessments and served as part of diagnostic teams. Each one had its own challenges and rewards. But my most meaningful responsibility was working with the parents or care givers of children with disabilities. By helping them recognise and understand and navigating them through their emotional turmoil in the years that followed was not an easy task. No textbook had prepared me with the knowledge and expertise for this challenge. Decades ago, many children with disabilities were educated separately, institutionalised, or simply not diagnosed. Fortunately, today we have come a long way in determining, understanding and accepting these disabilities. There are accommodations often provided by

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THEFT OF FAITH IN AYODHYA: ACCOUNTABILITY MUST APPLY EQUALLY

The allegations surrounding the Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust deserve an impartial and transparent investigation. Whenever institutions handling public donations face serious accusations of financial irregularities, the response must inspire confidence rather than deepen public suspicion.The issue goes beyond one trust or one organisation.

It concerns the principle that accountability must be uniform regardless of the stature or ideological affiliation of those involved.

If allegations involve inflated land deals, procedural violations or financial impropriety, they should be examined through an independent investigation that commands public credibility.

Superficial inquiries only weaken confidence in institutions.

The public also expects consistency in the functioning of investigative agencies.

Allegations of corruption should receive the same degree of scrutiny irrespective of whether they concern political opponents, religious trusts or influential organisations.

Selective enforcement undermines the rule of law and erodes trust in democratic institutions.Millions of devotees contribute to religious trusts with faith that their offerings will be used responsibly.

That faith deserves protection through transparency, professional audits and credible oversight. Only an impartial investigation, free from political considerations, can establish the truth and reinforce public confidence in India's institutional framework.

S. PADMANABHAN | KOCHI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

The reverse brain drain needs better planning

The return of thousands of Indian IT professionals from the United States should have been an opportunity to strengthen India's technology ecosystem. Instead, it has exposed the widening gap between expectations and employment opportunities. More than 7,300 professionals have already returned in 2026 after job losses in major American technology companies and the expiry of H-1B visas. Unfortunately, India's own IT industry is currently experiencing a hiring slowdown.Many of these professionals possess world-class expertise acquired at leading global firms. However, their expectations of salaries comparable to those in the United States often place them beyond the reach of most Indian employers.

While Global Capability Centres and startups are creating some opportunities, they remain insufficient to absorb such a large pool of experienced talent. Incentives for innovation, support for high-value research, entrepreneurship programmes, and policies encouraging technology-intensive investments can help utilise this valuable human capital. Returning professionals should also consider flexible compensation structures and entrepreneurial ventures.India cannot afford to let such highly skilled talent remain underutilised. A reverse brain drain should become an advantage, not a story of shattered aspirations. DATTAPRASAD SHIRODKAR |

MUMBAI

Govt must remove passport confusion

The Government's clarification that a passport is merely a travel document and not proof of citizenship has left many citizens puzzled. For decades, Indians have regarded the passport as one of the most rigorously verified documents issued by the Government. Obtaining one involves detailed scrutiny of identity, address and background, making it appear to represent official recognition of citizenship.

India does not permit dual citizenship and requires citizens acquiring foreign nationality to surrender their Indian passports. This practice naturally reinforces the public perception that possession of an Indian passport reflects Indian citizenship.

Legally, citizenship is determined under the Citizenship Act through birth, descent, registration or naturalisation, while a passport is issued primarily to facilitate international travel. Yet the distinction between the two has not been adequately communicated to ordinary citizens. The Government should issue a comprehensive public explanation outlining the legal relationship between citizenship and passport issuance. Such clarification is essential to remove unnecessary confusion and reassure citizens that their identity and legal status remain secure.

DVG SANKARA RAO | VIZIANAGARAM

Peace requires truth and equal justice

The clarification issued by the Kuki-Zo Council regarding its chairman's apology highlights the complexities of the continuing ethnic conflict in Manipur. Expressing sympathy for the tragic killing of six Naga civilians is a humanitarian gesture and should not automatically be interpreted as an admission of collective responsibility. Equally, the concerns expressed by Naga organisations reflect the deep mistrust that continues to prevail.

Lasting peace cannot be achieved through competing narratives or mutual accusations. The only sustainable path forward is a fair, impartial and time-bound investigation to identify the actual perpetrators and bring them to justice. Justice must neither be selective nor influenced by ethnic or political considerations.

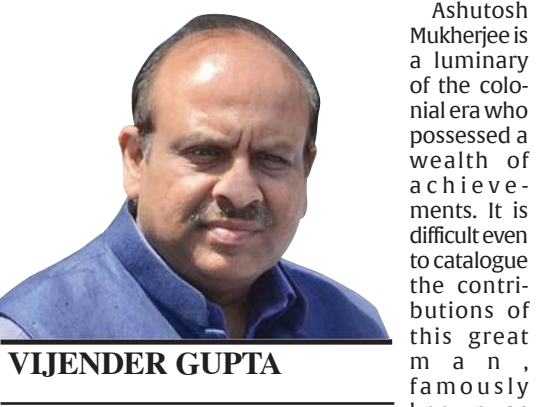
At the same time, every instance of violence must be investigated. The suffering of one community should never diminish the pain of another. Equal justice is essential for reconciliation.

Manipur urgently needs confidence-building measures, impartial law enforcement and sincere political dialogue. Genuine peace will emerge only when every community believes that justice is being delivered fairly and without prejudice.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Dr Ashutosh Mukherjee: The pioneer of Bengal’s intellectual awakening

At a time when colonial rule sought to constrain Indian aspirations, he transformed higher education into a vehicle of national awakening, championed Indian languages and research, defended academic autonomy, and left an enduring imprint on the judiciary and public life.



Ashutosh Mukherjee is a luminary of the colonial era who possessed a wealth of achievements. It is difficult even to catalogue the contributions of this great man, famously known as the “Bengal Tiger.” The world knows him as a great educationist and as the Vice-Chancellor of the University of Calcutta, but his personality was multidimensional.

Ashutosh Mukherjee was born on 29th June 1864 into the lineage of the great poet Krittivas Ojha, author of the Bengali Ramayana, to Dr. Gangaprasad Mukherjee. Unfortunately he passed away at the age of just 59. Even in his short life, the contributions he made in the fields of education, justice, mathematics, literature, and public life are inscribed in golden letters in the history of modern India. The present age seems to have all but forgotten this intellectual giant of history. Today, on the occasion of his 162nd birth anniversary, there is an opportunity to remember him with reverence.

Ashutosh Mukherjee was a brilliant student from childhood. At Presidency College, he kept company with stalwart students such as Swami Vivekananda, Prafulla Chandra Ray, and Mahendranath Roy. He was the first student of the university to obtain a double degree-an M.A. in Mathematics and an M.Sc. in Physics. Ashutosh wrote a book on geometric conics, which was widely acclaimed. Had he remained entirely in the field of mathematics, he could have become a world-renowned mathematician, but his talent was multifaceted. He was accomplished in all fields-mathematics, law, history, language, culture and what not.

In 1883, Surendranath Banerjee was arrested on charges of contempt of court in connection with an article criticising an order of the Calcutta High Court. This sparked protests, and a group of students under Ashutosh’s leadership decided to demonstrate right in front of the Calcutta High Court. Perhaps this incident further strengthened his resolve to build a career in the world of law. He began his legal studies at City College, Calcutta, where he won the ‘Tagore Gold Medal’ for three consecutive years (1884, 1885, and 1886). In 1888 he obtained his degree and registered as an advocate at the Calcutta High Court. He began working in the chambers of Rashbihari Ghosh, a leading barrister of the bar at that time.

In 1885, he married Yogmaya Devi Bhattacharya. They had seven children, of whom the second son, Dr. Shyama Prasad Mukherjee, carried forward his father’s legacy. Shyama Prasad became the youngest Vice-Chancellor of the University of Calcutta at the age of just 33. As independent India’s first Minister of Industry, he laid the industrial foundation of the country. By founding the Bharatiya Jana Sangh, he gave a renewed awakening to national consciousness. Proclaiming “In one country there shall not be two constitutions, two heads, and two emblems,” he struggled for the integration of Jammu and Kashmir and, in 1953, sacrificed his life under mysterious circumstances. Sir Ashutosh and the world of education could not be kept apart for long, and by 1897 he had obtained the degree of ‘Doctor of Law’ and taken up the position of ‘Tagore Law Professor’ at the University of Calcutta. On 5 August 1899, the University of Calcutta sent him to the Bengal Legislative Council, where he played the role of an extremely active member for the next five years. In the Council, together with Surendranath Banerjee, he opposed the Mackenzie Bill on each of its clauses, because it was undemocratic and unjust.

The purpose of this municipal law, in keeping with Lord Curzon’s tendency, was on the one hand to bring the Calcutta Municipality under government control, and on the other to give precedence to European commercial interests at the cost of the interests of Indian taxpayers-even though in reality it was the Indian taxpayers who were the greatest mainstay of the municipal system.

Ashutosh Mukherjee firmly advocated for the interests of teachers and opposed the existing disparity in the pay scales of the education service compared with the judicial and executive services. He said, “You appoint both in the same college. The work taken from them is also



VICEROY LORD CURZON INVITED SIR ASHUTOSH TO BECOME A JUDGE OF THE CALCUTTA HIGH COURT. HE SAID THAT IF HIS MOTHER PERMITTED, HE WOULD ACCEPT THE POSITION. UPON RECEIVING HIS MOTHER’S CONSENT, HE ASSUMED THE OFFICE OF JUDGE IN 1904 AND REMAINED IN THAT POST UNTIL 1923

of exactly the same nature; yet when the question of remuneration arises, you pay one double the salary of the other.”

In 1902, Sir Ashutosh was appointed a member of the University Commission. On 4 January 1904, Sir Ashutosh became a member of the Imperial Legislative Council. Even in his brief tenure, he left a mark that would be remembered for a long time. In the Imperial Council, he strongly opposed Curzon’s University Bill alongside Gokhale. As a member of the Calcutta University Commission (Sadler Commission: 1917-19), he made a noteworthy contribution.

Sir Ashutosh Mukherjee’s greatest contribution lies in the development of the University of Calcutta. He dedicated the University of Calcutta to the service of the nation. The establishment of departments of Indian languages was the crowning achievement of his life, making it possible to obtain the highest degrees in one’s mother tongue. He promoted research. He demonstrated that Indian universities could provide research and higher education even without foreign aid.

He emphasised the harmony of technical education, industry, and education. The University had its own press and published the ‘Journal of the Department of Letters.’ During Sir Ashutosh’s tenure as Vice-Chancellor, extensive work was done on ancient Indian history, language, culture, economics, and scientific subjects. He encouraged scholars to study Maratha history, Prakrit literature, and the like.

As Vice-Chancellor, he was under heavy pressure to expel Subhas Chandra Bose from the university for the assault on Professor Oten. Concerned about protecting the career of the young Bose, Ashutosh had him transferred to another college-the Scottish Church Missionary College. Since the colonial government regarded the University as a hotbed of sedition and sought to impose conditions and controls on the functioning of the Vice-Chancellor, Sir Ashutosh declined a sixth term.

Viceroy Lord Curzon invited Sir Ashutosh to become a judge of the Calcutta High Court. He said that if his mother permitted, he would accept the position. Upon receiving his mother’s consent, he assumed the office of judge in 1904 and remained in that post until 1923, during which time he also twice held charge as Acting Chief Justice. Of the hundreds of judgments Sir Ashutosh delivered as a judge, many are still cited today as examples of judicial skill.

Sir Ashutosh was a devout Hindu by faith and every year performed Durga Puja with great grandeur at his house in Bhowanipore. He was highly progressive in social matters and opposed untouchability. Even while bearing the opposition of the orthodox Hindus of the time, he had his widowed daughter remarried. For this act Ashutosh had to endure a great deal, but he remained unshaken. He held immense respect for other religions.

Owing to his inclination towards Buddhism, he served as President of the Maha Bodhi Society of India from 1911 to 1924. On 25 May 1924, in Patna, the mortal frame of the Bengal Tiger, Dr. Ashutosh Mukherjee, came to an end; but his ideas, the institutions he built, and his roar for truth and justice continue to inspire the ages even today.

The author is the Speaker of the Delhi Legislative Assembly

Land grievances need triage, not theatre



VIVEK KUMAR SINGH

Land grievances dominate public grievance forums across India. Whether in Janata Durbars, district grievance hearings, public outreach programmes or online complaint portals, land-related complaints invariably account for a disproportionate share of administrative attention. Yet they also expose a fundamental contradiction in governance. Citizens approach these forums expecting solutions, while the officials hearing them often lack the legal authority to provide one. The resulting disappointment erodes public trust in the State. The opposite response is equally problematic. Faced with public expectations, media scrutiny and social media amplification, grievance forums sometimes drift into areas reserved for courts or statutory bodies. Complex disputes are discussed in public, competing claims are examined before cameras, and directions are issued beyond jurisdiction.

Public grievance forums should function as intelligent gateways into the land-governance ecosystem by identifying the nature of grievances, assessing their urgency and directing them to the appropriate institutional pathway. In short, they should operate as triage centres, not adjudication centres. The problem begins with language itself. The expression “land dispute” is used so loosely that it conceals more than it reveals. What administrators encounter at the cutting edge are not merely disputes but a much wider spectrum of land ailments. Encroachments on government land, disputes regarding possession of public land, eviction from settled land, family partition disagreements, private access-road disputes, measurement and demarcation issues, grievances arising from revenue proceedings, non-compliance with judicial orders and matters already pending before courts are all routinely grouped under the same label. Yet they are fundamentally different problems requiring fundamentally different remedies.

Field experience suggests that most grievances reaching public forums fall into a limited number of recurring categories. Each category points towards a different authority, a different legal framework and a different pathway to resolution. An encroachment case requires administrative enforcement. A demarcation dispute requires technical measurement. A matter pending before a civil court requires judicial determination rather than administrative intervention. The mistake is to expect a public grievance forum to resolve all of them. Such an expectation places both citizens and administrators in an impossible position. Citizens arrive seeking immediate relief, while officials are often constrained by law, jurisdiction and procedure. The resulting gap between expectation and authority becomes a source of frustration and mistrust. The challenge is compounded by the fact that land grievances rarely remain confined to legal questions. They frequently involve social relationships, economic interests, local power structures and community tensions. A seemingly minor boundary disagreement can escalate into violence. A disputed pathway can disrupt access to homes and farms. Left unattended, many such grievances eventually transform into litigation, law-and-order problems or political controversies.

This is precisely why public grievance forums matter. Their significance lies not in deciding every matter brought before them, but in identifying problems early and ensuring that grievances enter the correct institutional pathway before they escalate. Once a land grievance is received, the crucial question is not, “Who is right?” but “What kind of problem is this?” An encroachment, a demarcation dispute, a pending civil suit and a compliance failure may all arrive at the same public hearing, but they belong to entirely different institutional pathways. Public grievance forums are therefore best viewed as the triage centres of land governance. Their role is to classify grievances, assess their conflict potential, route them to the appropriate authority and monitor progress.

The effectiveness of the forum depends less on its ability to decide matters on the spot and more on its ability to ensure that each grievance enters the correct pathway before it escalates into litigation. Many States already possess statutory mechanisms that can be better leveraged through such triage. Bihar, for instance, has a time-bound public grievance redressal framework as well as a specialised mechanism under the Bihar Land Disputes Resolution Act for specified categories of disputes. A triage protocol can provide the missing connective tissue between public hearings and these existing forums. The objective is not to create new institutions but to make existing ones work better. This distinction is critical. Public grievance forums should not become parallel courts. Questions of title, inheritance, easement rights and adjudication belong to institutions specifically created for those purposes. Grievance forums should not become passive listening posts that merely record complaints and generate acknowledgements. The challenge, therefore, is to strike a balance between helplessness and overreach. A triage-based approach respects institutional mandates while ensuring that citizens are not left to navigate a fragmented administrative system on their own. When grievance forums attempt to perform functions assigned to courts or statutory authorities, they inadvertently weaken those institutions. Conversely, when citizens leave public hearings without a clear pathway forward, confidence in governance suffers. A triage model avoids both outcomes by ensuring that every institution performs its designated role while remaining accountable for results. The success of public grievance forums should not be judged by the number of petitions heard or disposed of. Instead, it should be measured by the number of grievances correctly routed towards resolution. Disposal is an event. Resolution is an outcome. Every district should consider adopting a Land Grievance Triage Protocol. Such a framework would classify grievances into predefined categories, assess their conflict potential and route them to designated statutory pathways-whether under service-delivery legislation, specialised land-dispute mechanisms, survey processes or judicial forums. The objective would be to shift attention from disposal to resolution. India’s land governance challenges are too complex to be addressed through improvisation. They require clarity of roles, institutional discipline and structured coordination. Public grievance forums have an important role to play. Not every grievance can be resolved at a grievance forum.

Every grievance, however, can be correctly diagnosed there. Governance credibility is built when citizens know that their problem has been correctly identified, routed to the right institution and followed through to resolution. The challenge before land administration is not to make public grievance forums more dramatic. It is to make them more diagnostic. The future of land governance lies not in theatre, but in triage.



Vivek Kumar Singh is presently Chairman, RERA Bihar. As Principal Secretary, Department of Revenue and Land Reforms, Bihar, he had ushered in comprehensive digitisation of Land Records

Gen Z and shifting workforce preferences



DEEPIKA KUMAR

Recent news points to the fact that, of late, skilled plumbers earn more than entry-level engineers in tech firms such as Infosys and TCS (Link). In another post, Abhiraj Singh Bahl, co-founder and CEO of Urban Company, highlighted that some of the skilled service professionals on the platform earn in excess of ₹40,000 per month, which often exceeds the starting salaries in several IT roles in India. It is an interesting anomaly to what we’ve studied in economics around sectoral evolution of economies. What does this imply for Gen-Z and Alpha workforces as they enter and adapt to new workforce shifts and dynamics?

As per Morgan Stanley Research report “Asia Faces Rising Youth Unemployment Challenge”- India has ~17 per cent youth unemployment in the age group of 16-24, closely followed by Indonesia and China. Part of this is being attributed to the massive explosion in AI across the world, that has taken away entry-level jobs. The remainder is being shaped by geopolitical turmoil and tensions, leading to cost-cutting and localisation of labour supply as time passes by.

In addition, India also faces a special challenge of underemployment (lower productivity) in primary sector jobs especially agriculture and

mining, where more people are employed for a relatively lesser GDP contribution from the sector (high labour factor productivity ratio).

A case study of China

Gen Z workers in China are finding new ways to tackle an absence of jobs (which also, partly includes the problem of absence of meaningful employment). A lot of them are resorting to blue-collared jobs, in the absence of white-collared jobs.

The story of Zhang Weibo, who graduated from NTU (Nanyang Technical University) and decided to take up a blue collared job after leaving a white collared one, is an interesting case in point here. A sense of disillusionment with his white collared job, the feeling of restrictive-ness and a communal sense of discontent shared with others who join him in his cleaning efforts, provide impetus and strength to his decision. Link

Another social movement that has emerged in China is “Tongping” which means to lay flat - do the bare minimum - no work, no family, no home, no kids. A life of minimalism. Choosing what one wishes to do. Originally started as a movement against corporate slavery, the movement has now grown to accommodate (or rather, de-accommodate all forms of work). People who take this philosophy to the extreme, are choosing to go homeless, sleep-in restaurants and cafeterias than work to pay rent. Link

This one’s my favourite now - there’s a concept of “full-time children” where children continue to stay with parents long after they have graduated/post-graduated, and take care of



domestic chores (cleaning, cooking, feeding) and earn a salary from their own parents.

Meanwhile, in South Korea, a report by Korean Employment Information Service (KEIS) highlights that, in the 15-29 age group, about 18% were NEETs in 2024 (“Not in employment, education or training”). While partly driven by the need for mandatory military service, especially for male members of society, overall population numbers have been on the higher side, and the category of “non-seeking” population has grown even more in this case - spelling troublesome long-term unemployment trends.

A survey by Intelligent.com, a career advisory platform, highlights that “1 in 6 companies are hesitant to hire recent college graduates” and cite several reasons - including a lack of motivation, professionalism, inability to articulate and communicate well, and a poor work ethic, amidst others. In other words, employers are not partic-

ularly excited to hire an “anti-hustle” generation that seeks to work on its own terms, from anywhere, and for whatever amount of time.

Coming back to the problem at hand in India, the global trends point towards economic frictions and geopolitical tensions that cause similar challenges across regions, especially in Asia, a booming demographic. In India however, the challenge is even more layered, as education (and as a consequence, a job) is not entirely an independent choice but driven by societal and family norms. A lot of the so-called manual labour jobs (plumbing, cleaning, delivery) are looked down upon in most families, which believe that doing this would be a waste of a college degree that the society has collectively invested in. People choose to endlessly spend time preparing for exams, sitting idle and doing nothing over finding a money-making job, merely to live upto social standards.

In India, work is not just a means of survival, to earn bread and butter, but a huge part of social identity. Indian society, historically, was structured around a division based on occupation - an occupational dictionary was written up in the Manusmriti and used to divide society. Centuries later, we still run with archaic occupational dictionary that continues to reward intellectual labour over manual labour. Except, unfortunately, as times and realities change, circumstances change, is there perhaps a need to update how we view work fundamentally in its myriad shapes and forms? Another challenge that persists now is, that unlike major economies of the world, India grew on the backbone of soft industries, in other

words, tertiary and service sectors which are plateauing (or perhaps reaching the cusp of a new S-curve that’ll be driven by AI). Whether that’ll lead to more jobs or less, and of what kind, remains to be seen. But it clearly means a reconfiguration of job needs, requirements, and job descriptions - one that doesn’t exist. A lot of traditional need for STEM graduates is also going to change.

I will not be winding down this article neatly in clear conclusions, it is a work-in-progress discussion. This is merely an acknowledgement of how layered and systemic the problem of unemployment could be, and how social norms add to, and subtract from the same. What I’d choose to allude to is, much like corporates, a lot of learning (hard and soft-skills) could occur even in manual, so called “blue-collared” jobs. Sincerity, showing up for work every single day, building relationships, getting a pulse of what a client wants, and handling different customers/clients — all of these skills could very well be learnt from these jobs as much as any white-collared job. One could grow in a different way, through local networks and regional awareness, plug in customer gaps and build businesses, if they enter these jobs with the right intent and mindset. Perhaps a collegiate/institutional academic life isn’t necessary and supposedly right for everyone. And the wage differential above a lot of entry-level jobs, is already showing up in market statistics. Looking down upon these jobs is no longer an option.

The writer holds MBA from IIM Bangalore and worked as an Engagement Manager at McKinsey



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Order Order

MACT awards ₹23 lakh to man for permanent disability



A Delhi Motor Accident Claims Tribunal has awarded over ₹23 lakh to a man who suffered grievous injuries and permanent disability in a 2020 road accident.

Presiding Officer Sudeep Raj Saini was hearing a claim petition filed by Parmanand Rai, who suffered permanent disability after being hit by a car in 2020. In an order dated June 9, the tribunal said, "...the accident in question was caused due to rash and negligent driving of offending car, being driven by respondent no. 1, Devender."

According to the tribunal, Rai was crossing the road in Najafgarh on the night of February 29, 2020, when a speeding car hit him. The tribunal held that the accident occurred due to the rash and negligent driving of the offending car, relying on the Detailed Accident Report, the petitioner's testimony, medical records and the charge sheet. According to the court proceedings, Rai was working as a vegetable seller at the time of the accident. The tribunal assessed Rai's functional disability and loss of earning capacity at 30 per cent and awarded ₹23.16 lakh in compensation to him under various heads. The tribunal noted that the car was insured at the time of accident and directed the insurance company to deposit the compensation amount to the victim.

(PTI)

₹40 lakh compensation to elderly man in mishap claim



A Delhi Motor Accident Claims Tribunal here has awarded ₹40 lakh compensation to an elderly man who suffered permanent disability after being hit by a speeding motorcycle and allowed the insurance company to recover the amount from the vehicle owner and rider. Presiding Officer Sudeep Raj Saini was hearing a claim petition filed by Rajpal Singh (66), who suffered quadriplegia and became completely dependent on others for care following the accident. In the order dated June 9, the tribunal said, "It stands proved on the touchstone of preponderance of probabilities that the accident in question was caused due to rash and negligent driving of motorcycle being driven by respondent no 1, Irfan." According to the tribunal, Singh was hit by the speeding motorcycle while crossing a road near Akash Hospital on December 25, 2018. He sustained grievous injuries and was taken to Safdarjung Hospital and later to Venkateshwar Hospital. The tribunal relied on the eyewitness testimony, the Detailed Accident Report, prompt registration of the FIR, filing of chargesheet against the rider and other material on record. Noting that the victim suffered 100 per cent functional disability and a total loss of earning capacity, the tribunal awarded him ₹16.63 lakh towards future loss of income, over ₹11 lakh towards future attendant charges and compensation under other heads, including treatment expenses, pain and suffering, conveyance and special diet. The tribunal directed that 10 per cent of the total award amount of ₹40 lakh be released immediately, while the remaining 90 per cent be kept in fixed deposits under the Motor Accident Claims Annuity Deposit (MACAD) scheme. It noted that the motorcycle was insured at the time of the accident and directed the insurance company to deposit the compensation amount within 30 days. The tribunal also granted the company recovery rights against the driver, Irfan, and the motorcycle owner, Imran Uddin, after finding that the rider did not possess a valid driving licence at the time of the accident, amounting to a breach of the insurance policy.

(PTI)

Plea in SC seeks national fire and life safety framework

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A plea has been filed in the Supreme Court seeking a direction to the Centre and others to frame a national fire and life safety framework for high-risk public occupancy premises across the country.

The plea said the framework should cover schools, coaching centres, hostels, hotels, guest houses, bed-and-breakfast establishments, restaurants, malls, cinema halls, hospitals and other commercial premises with high footfall.

The petition, filed by advocate Narendra Kumar Goswami, also sought directions to all the states and



Union territories to conduct within three-four months a special fire and life safety audit of high-risk public occupancy premises, prioritising coaching hubs, schools, hospitals, hotels, restaurants, banquet halls and malls.

Referring to some of the worst fire tragedies in India, including some recent ones



Justice Narasimha to be now part of SC Collegium

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Justice PS Narasimha is set to become a member of the Supreme Court Collegium with the retirement of Justice JK Maheshwari on Sunday.

Being the fifth senior-most judge, Justice Narasimha will officially be a part of the Collegium until he retires on May 2, 2028.

Justice Maheshwari retired on Sunday, demitting office after a nearly five-year tenure.

The Collegium will now comprise Chief Justice Surya Kant, Justice Vikram Nath, Justice BV Nagarathna, Justice MM Sundresh and Justice PS Narasimha. Under the Collegium system, which came into existence in 1993 after a Supreme Court judgement, five top judges of the apex



court recommend the appointment, transfer and elevation of judges to the Supreme Court and 25 high courts.

The government can return the recommendation to the Collegium under this system. While it usually accepts the recommendation if it is reiterated by the Collegium, there have been cases when the government returned the

file or did not respond to the recommendation.

Born on May 3, 1963, in Hyderabad, Justice Narasimha graduated with triple majors in economics, political science and public administration from the Nizam College, Hyderabad, and pursued law at the Campus Law Centre, Delhi University, in 1988. Enrolled as

an advocate in the same year, he practised in the high court, civil courts and tribunals in Hyderabad, before shifting his counsel practice to the Supreme Court. He appeared in a large number of cases before the Supreme Court, including those of the Constitution benches.

During this time, he was appointed the commission counsel for the Justice Chinnappa Reddy Commission. He was also a member of the Supreme Court Legal Aid Committee.

Justice Narasimha was designated as a senior advocate by the full court of the Supreme Court in 2008. As a senior advocate, he appeared in many public law cases involving constitutional, administrative and environmental issues.

Court restrains Chandni Chowk shop owner from selling, dealing with fake Tag Heuer products

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has restrained a shop owner near New Lajpat Rai Market in Chandni Chowk here from using, selling, soliciting, and displaying imitation products of Swiss luxury watchmaker Tag Heuer.

District Judge Anubhav Jain was hearing the plea of the plaintiff, Switzerland-based M/s Tag Heuer S A, according to which it had learnt that some people, including the defendant (the shop owner), are using marks identical or similar to it.

"The said marks and labels adopted and being used by

the defendant are fraudulent and obvious imitations of the plaintiff's respective registered and prior used marks, and the defendant maliciously and fraudulently adopted and started using the respective impugned marks, being influenced by and inspired by the plaintiff's marks," the plea said.

The defendants are violating the plaintiff's rights in the said marks and labels, it said.

"The defendant is not only making the retail sales but is also supplying the impugned trade marks to various other dealers/shopkeepers/retailers in Delhi, including New Delhi, who are making the clandestine and surreptitious



sales thereof to the ultimate unwary consumers in Delhi," the plea said.

It sought that the defendant be restrained from manufacturing, marketing, or otherwise dealing with the counterfeit goods with similar or identical marks to the plaintiff. In an order dated June 9,

the court said after the filing of the present suit in January 2016, the court had appointed a local commissioner who inspected the defendant's shop bearing no. 17 B, Pleasure Garden Market, New Lajpat Rai Market, Near Gauri Shankar Mandir, Chandni Chowk.

Court acquits man booked for carrying 10 kg marijuana citing procedural breach

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has acquitted a man booked under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act for allegedly carrying 10 kg of ganja, citing procedural breach and several other infirmities.

The court said the prosecution failed to comply with mandatory procedures prescribed under Section 52A of the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, which mandates the preparation of any inventory and clicking photographs and submitting it before a



magistrate for verification.

Special Judge Jitendra Pratap Singh was hearing the case against Amjad Mandal, against whom the Vasant Kunj North police station had registered a case under the NDPS Act.

The court said the prosecution also failed to comply with rules mandating that a

copy of any "secret information" had to be forwarded to the immediate superior officer of the seizing officer within 72 hours.

According to the prosecution, the narcotics squad of the southwest district received "secret information" that the accused was carrying ganja and proceeding towards Kishan Garh village on September 10, 2018, based on which Mandal was apprehended with 10 kg of ganja.

It said the samples were sent to the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL), Rohini, for examination, and after completion of the investigation, a chargesheet was filed.

Justice does not mean whatever I want: Bombay HC raps law student

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court has pulled up a law student for making "reckless and irresponsible" statements while challenging a university's decision to bar her from appearing for final exams due to poor attendance, observing that justice does not mean "whatever I want and howsoever I put it".

The Aurangabad bench of Justices Vibha Kankanwadi and Ajit Kadethankar dismissed the 23-year-old's plea, noting that her attempts to overcome her own faults through false claims consti-

tuted an "abuse of process" that could jeopardise her career in the legal profession.

The court, in its judgment dated June 18, noted that any cause taken up before the courts of law must be bona fide.

"Every proceeding before a court is to seek justice; but the concept of 'justice' doesn't mean 'whatever I want and howsoever I put it,' the court said.

The petitioner, a postgraduate student at the Maharashtra National Law University in Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar, had challenged the institution's decision to bar her from appear-



ing for her final semester examinations for failing to meet the mandatory 75 per cent attendance requirement. After a single bench dismissed her initial plea in

April, she filed a review petition seeking a direction for the University to conduct a special examination.

The student, in her plea, claimed there was an error in

Thane court sentences man to life imprisonment for wife's murder



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

A court in Maharashtra's Thane district has sentenced a 32-year-old man to life imprisonment for the brutal murder of his wife, whom he set ablaze during a quarrel in 2020.

Additional Sessions Judge BD Shelke on Friday found the accused, Shahir Devram Parkhe, a resident of Kalyan, guilty under section 302 (murder) of the Indian Penal Code (IPC), and imposed a fine of ₹5,000 on him.

He also took a stern stance against a key eyewitness, who turned hostile, ordering her prosecution for perjury.

As per the case details, on the intervening night of March 17 and 18, 2020, Parkhe quarrelled with his wife, Payal, who called her close friend home to mediate and settle the dispute. Later, the accused, who was inebriated, fetched a plastic bottle containing kerosene and poured it over her, set her ablaze and fled the scene.

Payal had entered a love marriage with Parkhe, and the couple resided in the Daighar area of Thane. According to the prosecution, the accused suspected

his wife's character, leading to frequent disputes and cruelty. The victim suffered 70 per cent burns and succumbed at a hospital a few days later.

Additional public prosecutor Sanjay More examined 10 prosecution witnesses. Judge Shelke analysed dying declarations made by the victim to the police, the executive magistrate, neighbours, and her mother. A significant aspect of the trial involved the victim's friend, Kajal Mourya, who was an eyewitness to the initial sequence of events. During her cross-examination by the defence, she claimed that the victim had mistakenly ignited herself and alleged that her original statements to the police and magistrate were given under "pressure".

The court, however, noted that she had never lodged any formal complaint regarding such coercion and had affirmed standard details about the couple's disputes and the immediate aftermath of the fire. Mourya had deliberately suppressed material facts, told lies, and intentionally given false evidence, it stated, and subsequently issued a formal show-cause notice to her.

Delhi HC denies interim bail to drugs smuggler for attending his sister's wedding

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has refused to grant interim bail to a man accused of trafficking narcotic substances and possessing over 40 kg of ganja. The accused sought interim bail for 20 days on humanitarian grounds to attend his sister's wedding ceremony in Bihar this month.

A vacation bench of Justice Tejas Karia dismissed the plea, stating that a strong case for denying interim bail was made out given the gravity of the offence alleged against the petitioner-



accused, the quantity of narcotics involved and his prior criminal antecedents.

Delhi Police opposed the interim bail plea, stating that the petitioner, arrested in the FIR registered in 2024 under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, is a

habitual offender. The police counsel said the accused was arrested for possessing more than 40 kg of ganja, which is a "commercial quantity" under the law, and there were other brothers who could perform the religious ceremonies at the sister's wedding.

Rave parties: Himachal Pradesh High Court orders transfer of DC, SP

her attendance computation and alleged that the college had granted extra attendance to certain students arbitrarily. She further claimed that the University had not considered her genuine medical circumstances.

The University opposed the plea, contending that the petitioner had recorded only 45 per cent attendance, and had it been at least 67 per cent, additional attendance would have been granted after due consideration.

It also claimed that the petitioner failed to attend the hearing held by the Grievance Redressal Committee before whom she

had filed an application before approaching the court, and instead challenged the committee's order refusing her relief, claiming it was arbitrary.

The court refused to accept the petitioner's contention that the University had given concessions to some students, observing that it was hearsay and there was no evidence to support the same.

It noted that the petitioner had made absolutely "reckless and irresponsible" contentions, raising a new story about her ill health in the review petition, but had not submitted any supporting documents.



and to initiate departmental proceedings against them.

The order was pronounced on June 24 and the detailed copy was released on Saturday.

The bench further ordered the registration of an FIR and the constitution of a Special

Investigation Team (SIT) headed by an officer not below the rank of Deputy Inspector General (DIG) to probe the matter and initiate departmental proceedings against the three officers.

Hearing a public interest litigation (PIL) on rave parties and drug abuse in Kullu and Mandi districts, the HC observed that the officials failed to maintain public order and instead facilitated the organisation of large-scale rave parties despite prior warnings from the police about the possibility of drug consumption, trafficking and other unlawful activities.

Ancient Indian wisdom for sustainable living

मे माता पृथिवी महीयम् ।

Rigveda - 1.164.33

The manipulation of nature by humans to satisfy their needs has been a constant since their existence. However, the contemporary era has witnessed an unprecedented and exponential rise in human dominance over the environment. The current planetary imbalances fuelled by modern lifestyles manifested in climate change, frequent disasters, environmental pollution, biodiversity loss, etc., endangering human lives and natural resources. In this context, the ancient Indian philosophical systems and spiritual traditions that emphasise an intrinsic and harmonious relationship between humans and nature, offer valuable insights for environmental conservation. The advocated ideas of *Dharma*, *Ahimsa* and *Prakriti Pujan* remind us of the need for sustainable living and offer subsequent hope for damage control or environmental recovery.

परस्परोग्रहो जीवानाम् ।

Jain Tattvartha Sutra - 5.21

Dharma (Dhamma in Pali and Prakrit) in ancient Indian thought signifies duty, righteous living, or social order, often linked to the protection of truth, justice, or ethical conduct. It is central to texts such as, the Vedas, Upanishads, Mahabharata, Bhagavad Gita and Kautilya's Arthashastra. Specifically, from an ecological perspective, the Ayurvedic idea of *Loka-Purusha-Saamyā* highlights the interdependence of all life forms and their environments, while the Vedic concept of *Rita* (natural law/cosmic order) underscores the need for moral action to maintain ecological balance. Vedic as well as Upanishadic traditions emphasize that humans do not have the authority to dominate the Earth but rather have a duty to protect and preserve it, viewing nature as an end in itself deserving of care and respect. Also, the Arthashastra promotes water conservation through irrigation taxes and Padma Purana condemns water pollution. This ethos continued in practice as well. For example, Emperor Ashoka propagated Dhamma to instil moral responsibility in his Mauryan kingdom. During the 1730 Khejarli sacrifice, 363 Bishnois led by Amrita Devi in Rajasthan gave up their lives to protect trees, which inspired the later movements like Chipko (1973), Uttarakhand and Appiko (1983), Karnataka. Together, these traditions and movements reflect a longstanding belief that protecting nature is an essential part of Dharma and key to sustainable living.

Ahimsa (Ahinsa), or non-violence, signifies refrain-



JUSTICE VINEET SARAN

FORMER JUDGE,
SUPREME COURT
OF INDIA



NEHA G

JR. RESEARCH FELLOW,
BHARAT KI SOCH

ing from harm towards all living beings, a principle central to Buddhism and Jainism. It promotes compassion or *karuna* and respect for life in all forms. The Rigveda cautions against the destruction of forests, while the Vishnu Samhita discourages harm to plants and animals. Ashoka's edicts prohibited forest burning, regulated animal slaughter and protected wildlife, even extending to restrictions on agricultural practices harmful to living creatures. The Mauryan period also saw the establishment of veterinary care, with texts like Shalihotra Samhita detailing health treatments for elephants and horses, the important carriers/modes of transportation during war. Later, Akbar encouraged restraint in meat consumption, especially on sacred days. In modern times, Mahatma Gandhi transformed Ahimsa into a powerful tool of resistance during India's freedom struggle.

Prakriti Pujan is a key concept in Hindu thought, where elements like rivers, trees, animals, soil and the sun are revered as sacred. This ethos continues in festivals such as Chhath Puja, Van Mahotsav, Makar Sankranti, Pongal and Bihu. Vedic times perceived water as a symbol of spiritual purification with some hymns addressed to *Varuna*, the God of water. Ancient texts such as Rigveda mentions about

“

IN ANCIENT INDIAN THOUGHT, ECOLOGICAL BALANCE WAS A MORAL RESPONSIBILITY IN EVERYDAY LIFE - DHARMA GUIDED CONDUCT, AHIMSA LIMITED HARM AND REVERENCE FOR PRAKRITI SACRALISED THE NATURAL WORLD

”

Wisdom Word Search

V P N L B A N A H J K B

J G A L I B N B D I A R

R A V R M I B A E V A S

P R L J I N K Y I A K H

R P D A G B K U M B N T

A A M N B L E L I A O I

K A A A J A A S A I T P

R Y T I T X Y V A C L A

T J I D E F P U N I Q T

I A R Q P W A L A T D A

B A S T U T A N T R A K

A O U Q H U C A M Y I W

D U S H A N A V I A N O

WORDS TO FIND

Bana, Bayu, Brshtipata, Bastutantra, Dushana, Jalabayu, Jivabaicitrya, Mati, Paribesa, Prakrti

THE WISDOM LEXICON

BANA - Forest - A large area covered with trees and diverse wildlife.

BAYU - Air

BRSH TIPATA - Rainfall

BASTUTANTRA - Ecosystem: A community of organisms interacting with their environment.

DUSHANA - Pollution

JALABAYU - Climate

JIVABAICITRYA - Biodiversity

MATI - Soil

PARIBESA - Environment

PRAKRITI - Nature

Note: These terms come from Bengali, one of India's 22 Scheduled Languages.

Marvels of India

THE NADISTUTI SUKTA



Ancient Bharat's Hymn Dedicated to River Ecology

It is the 75th hymn of the 10th *Mandala* of the *Rigveda* that enumerates and praises the river systems of the Vedic civilisation.

The Hymn as a Hydrological Map

At least 19 rivers are invoked, listed from east to west, encompassing major rivers (Ganga, Yamuna, Kubha, Gomati, Krumu etc.) and the region of the *Sapta Sindhavah* (the seven core rivers): Sarasvati, Sindhu (Indus), Vitasta (Jhelum), Asikni (Chenab), Parushni (Ravi), Vipasha (Beas) and Shutudri (Sutlej). The "lost" Sarasvati is documented herein.

Rivers as Living Ecology, Not Mere Resources

Listing interconnected river networks spanning the northwestern Indian subcontinent implies an awareness of hydrological interdependence, i.e. rivers sustaining biodiversity, agriculture and settlement in arid terrains. This portrayal aligns with broader Vedic ecology, viewing rivers not merely as resources but as divine entities integral to a balanced ecology.

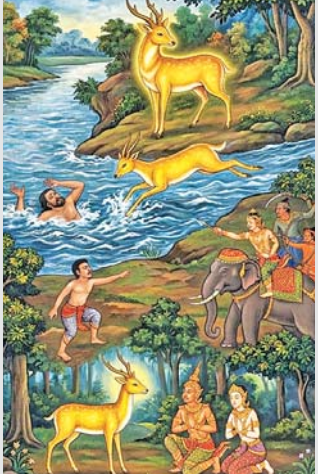
How Well the Ancient Indians Knew Their Landscape!

It is a marvel because it shows ancient Indians' precise knowledge of geography and the environment as early as 1500-1000 BCE.

Fable with Moral

The Ruru Jataka

(Jataka No. 482, the Pali Canon)



Ruru was a wondrous deer who lived in a dense forest. His coat gleamed like gold studded with jewel-like spots; his eyes were sky-blue, his hooves and antlers like polished stone. Possessing wisdom earned from past lives, he could speak human speech, yet he avoided people because of their cruel, greedy ways. Still, he felt compassion for all living beings.

One day Ruru heard a desperate cry and found a man being swept away by a raging stream. Without hesitation he plunged in, urged the man to hold on, and bore the terrified stranger to safety on the riverbank. Ruru warmed him with gentle nuzzles until he recovered. The grateful man vowed that his life now belonged to the deer and promised to serve him forever. Ruru cautioned the man to tell no one that such a beautiful creature had saved him, warning that humans were merciless. The man swore secrecy and left.

Later the queen dreamed of a golden deer preaching wisdom from a throne. Enchanted by the animal, she commanded the king to capture this deer. The king announced a reward: a rich village for whoever found the animal. The rescued man, tempted by the prize,

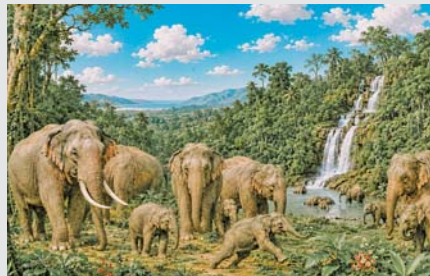
revealed Ruru's hiding place and led the king's hunters to the thicket. But when he raised his hand to point him out, his hand fell away as if punished for betrayal. Cornered by arrows and men, Ruru calmly addressed the king and asked how people had found his forest. The king pointed to the traitorous man. Ruru then declared, "Better to lift a log from the water than to save an ungrateful one," and told how he betrayed. Moved by the story, the king admired Ruru's bravery and was enraged at the man's ingratitude. As the archers prepared to punish the betrayer, Ruru pleaded mercy. The king forgave the man and, honoring Ruru's courage and wisdom, invited the deer to the court.

Ruru accepted, rode into the city in a royal carriage, and spent days delivering thoughtful discourses to the king, queen, and courtiers. After enlightening them, the deer returned to his forest home, leaving behind a lesson about compassion, gratitude, and the deceptive nature of human hearts.

Moral of the Fable: Be forgiving and get rid of your grudges

Did you know?

India's first elephant conservation laws are more than 2,000 years old. Long before modern wildlife conservation, ancient India had established strict laws to protect elephants. During the Mauryan Empire around 300 BCE, Chanakya's Arthashastra prescribed the creation of protected elephant forests known as Nagavanas. Elephants were considered vital state assets and the battle tanks of the ancient world. Hunting wild elephants was strictly prohibited and those found guilty of killing one could face the death penalty. Ancient India also developed sophisticated knowledge systems for elephant welfare. Texts such as the Palakapayam provided guidance on



elephant anatomy, veterinary medicine, and disease treatment. Similarly, the Matangaleela explored elephant behaviour, emotional wellbeing, ethical training, and care. More than two millennia ago, India recognised that protecting wildlife was essential for both statecraft and ecological stewardship, making it one of the world's earliest pioneers of wildlife conservation.

QUIZ

Environment & Sustainability

Questions	Option A	Option B	Option C	Option D
1 Which tribe from Arunachal Pradesh is famous for its grassroots wildlife conservation efforts, actively managing local eco-tourism and partnering with forest authorities to protect vital habitats?	Bugun	Lepcha	Idu Mishmi	Monpa
2 Visitors gather to witness the safe release of baby Olive Ridley Sea turtles into Arabian Sea, promoting community-driven ecotourism and conservation during this festival held annually. On which coast is it held?	Malabar	Konkan	Coromandel	Utkal
3 Which tribe is renowned globally for their traditional skills, helping the Tamil Nadu Forest Department with snake rescues and venom extraction without harming these reptiles?	Toda	Konda Reddy	Muthuvan	Irula
4 The Panzath Nag Festival is a traditional fishing and freshwater spring-cleaning event held annually. Where is this community-led festival held?	Kashmir	Uttarakhand	Himachal	Bihar
5 The Mughal Charbagh (four-quadrant) gardens were designed as micro-climatic sustainability systems. How did they achieve temperature moderation in hot regions?	By using dark volcanic stones that absorbed solar radiation	By dense afforestation of fruit trees at the outer perimeter	Through water channels and cascading waterfalls over white marble	By creating underground vacuum chambers beneath the lawns to trap cold air

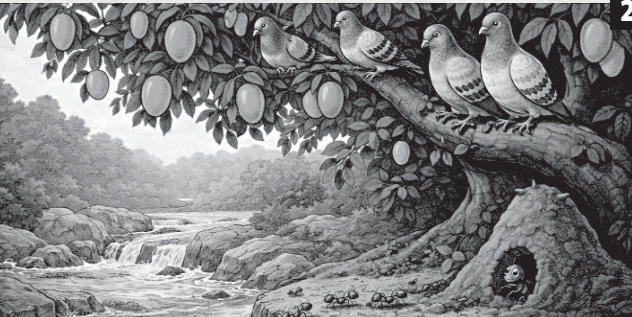
ANSWERS: 1 - A, 2 - B, 3 - D, 4 - A, 5 - C

panchatantra

The Ant and the Pigeon



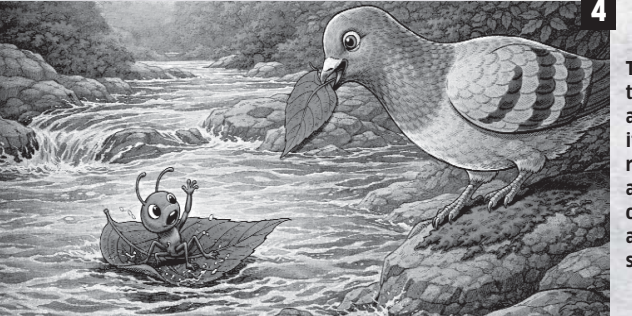
1



2



3



4



5



6

Once upon a time, there was a huge mango tree beside a mighty river. It bore big delicious mangoes. Many pigeons lived on the tree. Under that tree was an anthill.

Now, the ant looked for an opportunity to return the favour. One day he saw that a hunter was aiming his bow and arrow, hoping to catch some pigeons.

One day, a pigeon noticed an ant drowning in the river. The pigeon wanted to save the little ant.

The pigeon tore a leaf and threw it into the river. The ant climbed on the leaf and was saved.

Realising the danger, the ant rushed towards the hunter and bit his leg. The hunter yelled in pain while the pigeons sensing the danger flew away unharmed.

MORAL OF THE STORY: One Good Deed Begets Another

FROM THE WORLD

USA

Mango festival in Washington

Thousands turned up at the Dupont Circle in downtown Washington to get a taste of Indian mangoes and scrumptious biryani as the Embassy of India hosted a tasting session. Indian-Americans came to the Dupont Circle roundabout on Saturday from neighbouring Virginia and Maryland to relive the memories of yesteryears and relish the juiciest of mango varieties – Kesar, Langra, Malda and many more that were on offer. “I have memories of my grandmother serving us mangoes during the summers. I came here just to get a taste of Indian mangoes,” Disha, a US citizen born to Indian immigrant parents, said, relishing a plate of Kesar. “This is the yummiest of the mangoes I have ever had,” said Andrew, who is touring the US to watch the World Cup football.

SINGAPORE

Migrants to learn AI skills

The IIT Alumni Association in Singapore has started a programme to deliver structured digital literacy and Artificial Intelligence training to nearly 1,000 migrant workers, including Indians, in the city-state over the next two years. Supported by the Indian High Commission, the Indian Institutes of Technology Alumni Association - Singapore signed a Memorandum of Understanding with the Migrant Workers' Centre. The MWC is a 16-year-old bipartite effort between the National Trades Union Congress and the Singapore National Employers Federation to improve the welfare of migrant workers in Singapore. “HCI has been very actively involved in promoting this partnership. We started with financial literacy workshops at a few dormitories, and that it has culminated in an enduring partnership,” said Indian High Commissioner Dr Shilpak.

Six killed in major TTP terror attack on Karachi Rangers camp

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Karachi

At least three terrorists and three paramilitary soldiers were killed after heavily armed militants of the banned Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) attacked a compound belonging to the Sindh Rangers in Karachi, the army said on Sunday.

The attack — the port city's first major terrorist strike since October 2024 — on the Pakistan Rangers (Sindh) camp was carried out by terrorists belonging to Jamaat-ul-Ahrar, a splinter group of the TTP, the Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR), the military's media wing, said. The attack took place around 8.30 pm Saturday when the terrorists rammed a vehicle into the gate of the Sindh Rangers Bhattai wing in the densely populated Gulistan-e-Jauhar area, and stormed in and lobbed hand grenades, which led to multiple explosions.

A local resident said authorities told people to stay inside their homes and some residential buildings and areas witnessed power cut. At least three terrorists were killed in the attack, and one, believed to be an Afghan national, was captured alive, the army said without disclosing further details.

“The assailants, after a blast at (the) main gate of the camp, attempted to breach the perimeter security,” the

Trump wants new Syrian regime to fight Hezbollah

ABBY SEWELL ■ Beirut

As the White House has soured on Israel's war with Hezbollah in Lebanon, US President Donald Trump has shocked many in the region by pushing an alternative: Let Syria fight the Iran-backed militant group instead.

He has suggested that the battle-hardened and Islamist-led insurgents who overthrew Syria's autocratic President Bashar Assad a year and a half ago and formed a new government would do a better job of rooting out Hezbollah than the Israeli army.

Syrian President Ahmad al-Sharaa has said he has no interest in doing so, and has asserted that Trump's comments were misconstrued. But Trump has doubled down on the idea. Although it remains unclear how serious the



An Israeli flag tops a destroyed building in southern Lebanon

AP

White House is about the proposal, the prospect of a Syrian invasion has raised alarms in Lebanon — and also in Israel, which regards al-Sharaa's Islamist-led government with suspicion and has seized

control of a strip of southern Syria since he took power.

Syria has also become the site of rising tensions between Israel and Turkiye — a main backer of al-Sharaa's government — with each

seeking to limit the other's influence in the neighbouring country. Top Israeli security officials convened a meeting on the subject on Wednesday, according to an official who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to the media.

On the sidelines of the G7 summit earlier this month, Trump complained that Israel's war with Hezbollah is dragging on too long and “too many people are being killed.” More than 4,000 people have been killed by Israeli strikes in Lebanon since Hezbollah joined the wider Iran war with a March 2 attack on Israel, including hundreds of women and children.

Israel says its strikes target Hezbollah and that it takes measures to protect civilians. “You don't have to knock down an

apartment house every time you're looking for somebody, because there are a lot of people in those apartment houses and they're not all Hezbollah,” Trump said.

“I suggested to Israel to let Syria take care of Hezbollah. Cause to be honest with you, I think they'd do a better job.” Days later, on the first day of US-Iran talks in Switzerland, Fox News' Trey Yingst said that, during an interview, Trump had expressed disappointment that Israel can't “put Hezbollah away” and said that he is “close to giving it to Syria” because he thinks al-Sharaa would be more precise.

The White House declined to comment and referred to Trump's previous statements. Syrian officials scrambled to do damage control. In a speech in Damascus on June 13, al-Sharaa said, “There

are people spreading rumours that Syria will intervene in Lebanon. This is not true. We are calling for a permanent end to the war and the strengthening of institutions, and for there to be economic ties and a calming of the situation in Lebanon.” In a June 21 interview with the Emirati network Al Mashhad, al-Sharaa said Trump's remarks had been misunderstood.

Trump “spoke about Syria's role in finding a safe and peaceful solution, but the statement was misinterpreted as if Syria were going to invade Lebanon tomorrow morning,” al-Sharaa said.

He said Syria had “presented our vision for a solution to the United States, which is to stop the war and address the negative effects on Lebanon and Syria, and to find different economic, political and social solutions.” (AP)

Pakistan, Bahrain discuss latest regional situation amid renewed attacks by US, Iran

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
Islamabad

Pakistan and Bahrain on Sunday discussed the “latest regional situation” amid renewed attacks by the US and Iran threatening the fragile peace in the Gulf region.

The evolving situation in West Asia was discussed during a telephone conversation between Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar and Bahrain Foreign Minister Abdullatif bin Rashid Al Zayani, the Pakistan Foreign Office said.

The US and Iran signed a



Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar

memorandum of understanding (MoU) on June 18, aimed at restoring peace in West Asia. It was fol-

lowed by technical-level talks in Switzerland on June 21, with Pakistan and Qatar as mediators. Al Zayani

“appreciated Pakistan's constructive role in facilitating the understanding, expressing hope that it would contribute to lasting peace and stability in the region”, the statement said.

Dar, who is also Pakistan's foreign minister, reiterated Islamabad's resolve to “promote dialogue and diplomacy for achieving peace and stability in the region”, it added.

Bahrain has faced some of the fiercest attacks by Iran in response to the US strikes on the pretext of targeting US assets in that country. (PTI)

Iraqi officials, lawmakers arrested on corruption charges

QASSIM ABDUL-ZAHRA
Baghdad

Several Iraqi political officials were arrested early Sunday on corruption charges, Iraq's State-run Iraqi News Agency reported.

It said the arrests were based on statement made by former Deputy Minister of Oil Adnan al-Jumaili, who was arrested last month, and “included members of Parliament whose immunity had been lifted.”

Iraqi security forces sealed off all entrances to the capital's heavily fortified Green Zone early Sunday and carried out raids inside the compound that houses key government institutions and foreign embassies.

A security agency report obtained by The Associated Press said that seven people were arrested, among them five members of Parliament. Some of the arrestees were from the political bloc of former Prime Minister Mohammed Shia al-Sudani. It was not immediately clear what the specific accusations against them were.

Al-Sudani's bloc won the largest share of seats in November's parliamentary elections, but he ultimately stepped aside. (AP)



Adnan al-Jumaili



year, according to its operator's website. It is also a key source of petroleum products intended for export through Russia's Black Sea ports, including fuel oil, naphtha and marine fuel.

Photos and videos circulating on Russian social media showed a thick cloud of smoke over what users said was the Slavyansk facility. The Associated Press was not immediately able to verify the images.

Zelenskyy also claimed that a second Russian refinery, in the Yaroslavl region around 700 kilometers (435 miles) from the Ukrainian border, was hit during the nighttime strikes. There were no immediate reports from Russian authorities about the Ukrainian strike on the Yaroslavl refinery. Local Gov. Mikhail Evraev reported on Sunday morning that some roads between Moscow and the region's capital, Yaroslavl, were temporarily closed due to “an enemy attack by Ukrainian drones”.

Yaroslavl's airport also briefly closed overnight, along with others in southern and western Russia, according to the country's civil avi-

ation agency. For months, Ukraine has been stepping up attacks on energy facilities deep inside Russia, arguing the sector both funds and directly fuels the Kremlin's invasion. Despite a raft of Western sanctions, Moscow remains among the world's top exporters of oil and natural gas.

More recently, Ukraine has attempted to choke off fuel deliveries to Crimea, the Black Sea peninsula Moscow illegally annexed from it in early 2014. Last weekend, Kremlin-installed officials in Crimea suspended gasoline sales to civilians, after Kyiv's targeting of supply routes triggered the worst energy crisis there since the annexation.

Civilian fuel sales were also being restricted in Russia's Irkutsk region in Siberia, thousands of kilometers (miles) from the Ukrainian border, local Gov. Igor Kobzev announced on Sunday. Drivers will be barred from buying more than 50 litres of fuel per vehicle per day at state-run Rosneft gas stations in the province, Kobzev said, while “other gas stations may set lower limits.”



Indian Air Force aircraft arriving at Maiquetia International Airport, Caracas, carrying 66 tonnes of humanitarian aid- including an Indian Army Field Hospital, over 35 tonnes of relief supplies, medicines and medical equipment, and two BHISHM Cubes, for Venezuela as part of post-earthquake relief efforts

PTI

Skydiving plane crashes in northeastern France, 11 dead

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Nancy

A skydiving plane crashed in northeastern France on Sunday, killing all 11 people on board, authorities said.

The plane suffered a malfunction and “fell almost vertically” after taking off from the Nancy-Essey airfield on the outskirts of the city of Nancy, the region's prefect, Yves Seguy, said.

It crashed on the edge of a built-up area near the airfield, he told broadcaster BFM-TV. “Had it occurred just a few dozen metres away, the accident could have caused collateral casualties,” Seguy, prefect of the Meurthe-et-Moselle region, said. The plane belonged to a skydiving club and was taking part in a parachute



jump, he said. Emergency services responded immediately and were providing psychological support to

several relatives of the victims, he said. Authorities were also collecting witness statements, he said.

OIL COMPANY HELICOPTER CRASHES, IN SAUDI ARABIA, 14 PEOPLE DEAD

Dubai: All 14 people on board were killed in Saudi Arabia when a helicopter belonging to the world's largest oil company crashed on Sunday morning, according to the Saudi Ministry of Energy. The accident occurred around 6 am in Ras Tanura, and everyone killed was a Saudi national, the statement said. An investigation was opened into the cause of the crash. The helicopter belonged to Aramco, which is majority-owned by Saudi Arabia. Aramco recently has had to scramble as the Iran war disrupted oil supplies and



raised prices. The company has said it successfully shifted some oil exports to a pipeline to avoid the Strait of Hormuz, which has been disrupted as Iran asserted control over the waterway.

France records around 1,000 additional deaths amid heatwave

KIRSTEN GRIESHABER/JOHN LEICESTER ■ Berlin

France saw around 1,000 additional deaths last week at the height of its record-smashing heat wave, the country's public health agency said on Sunday, as Europeans elsewhere were suffering through yet another day of new temperature highs that sparked wildfires in Germany and had Berlin police using water cannons to cool down the crowds.

Temperature records were toppled in several countries on the weekend as the heat wave slowly moved toward eastern parts of the continent. In Germany, a new night

time temperature record was reported from Kubschutz, in eastern Saxony, where the temperature did not drop below 29.4 degrees Celsius. The nightly record came only hours after a daytime record of 41.5 C in Mockern-Drewitz in Saxony-Anhalt, according to preliminary data by the German Weather Service DWD. The previous record was set a day earlier.

A new study from the World Weather Attribution, a Europe-based collaboration of scientists, reported Friday that the record-breaking heat and humidity in Europe this week would not have been possible without climate change. The rapid

study found that the heat would have been virtually impossible just five decades ago, and is 200 times more likely today than it would have been 20 years ago.

France saw a surge in deaths last week at the height of its record-smashing heat wave, including a sharp increase in calls to private homes, especially in the Paris region, the national public health agency said Sunday.

There were more than 1,200 deaths on Wednesday, when France was sweltering under its hottest temperatures ever, increasing to more than 1,400 deaths on each of the two following days, Public Health France



said. In April and May, before the heat wave, France's rate of deaths was about 900 to 1,000 per day, it said.

The agency concluded that France experienced a total of at least 1,000 additional deaths during those three days alone, an estimate it cautioned is likely to increase as more data is collected, including for deaths at home.

The increase in deaths was sharpest in areas under red warnings of extreme heat, it said. Those warnings blanketed about three-quarters of the country at the peak of the heat wave. The agency said that 85 per cent of the deaths involved people aged 65 and above.

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60 pc professionals say AI now central to HR operations

Artificial intelligence (AI) is becoming central to human resource management, with 60 per cent of professionals surveyed saying it is now a top focus across HR functions, while another 15 per cent reported its growing importance in areas such as recruitment and onboarding, according to a survey-based report.

The 'AI As The New HR Priority – Efficiency, Cost and Workforce Impact' report is based on a survey among 1,811 HR professional across industries conducted between May 7-31.

Over 60 per cent of professionals believe AI is now a top priority across HR functions, while another 15 per cent say it is becoming a growing priority across recruitment, onboarding, routine HR operations, workforce staffing and HR solutions firm Genius HRTech DigiPoll Survey, 'AI As The New HR Priority – Efficiency, Cost and Workforce Impact' has revealed.

According to the findings of the report, 60 per cent of respondents identified improving efficiency and productivity as the primary reason for AI adoption, followed by 20 per cent who believe organisations are leveraging AI to reduce costs and optimise workforce management.

It found that AI is already transforming day-to-day HR operations, with 42 per cent of respondents reporting significant improvements in the speed and efficiency of HR processes and another 29 per cent noting moderate gains, indicating that automation is making recruitment, onboarding and employee services faster and more seamless.

(PTI)

US-Iran talks, macro data to dictate bullion trend next week

Developments surrounding US-Iran negotiations, movement in crude oil prices and key global economic data are expected to steer gold and silver prices next week, analysts said. The focus will squarely be on talks scheduled in Burgenstock, Switzerland, where US Vice President JD Vance is expected to lead discussions with Iranian officials to build on last week's framework agreement aimed at ending hostilities and reviving nuclear negotiations.

Analysts said the outcome of the talks could influence risk sentiment and energy markets, with implications for bullions. Domestic commodity markets will remain closed during the morning session on Friday on account of Muharram.

"Gold and silver momentum looks sideways/corrective as focus will remain on the negotiation between Washington and Tehran and also on the flow of crude oil, LNG and raw materials from the Strait of Hormuz," Pranav Mer, Vice President, EBG – Commodity & Currency Research, JM Financial Services Ltd, said.

The precious metals ended last week on a lower note amid a strong rupee and diminishing demand.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, gold futures declined ₹3,325, or 2.2 per cent, to close at ₹1.47 lakh per 10 grams. Silver slumped ₹13,001, or 5.3 per cent, to settle at ₹2.33 lakh per kilogram.

"Gold remained under pressure throughout the week, ending nearly 2.2 per cent lower as the precious metals faced headwinds from a combination of falling energy prices, a stronger Indian rupee, and a hawkish policy stance from the US Federal Reserve," Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst, Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, said.

A stronger rupee lowers the landed cost of imported gold, creating additional pressure on precious metals prices, he noted.

(PTI)

UPRERA issues show-cause to 76 realty promoters for failing to upload reports

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Uttar Pradesh Real Estate Regulatory Authority (UP RERA) has identified 76 projects whose promoters have not yet uploaded their annual audit reports for the financial year 2024-25 on the authority's web portal and have issued show-cause notices to all defaulting promoters.

UP RERA has directed all defaulting promoters to upload the pending audit reports within 15 days along with the prescribed late fee for the relevant financial year, failing which they

could face a penalty of up to five per cent of the estimated project cost.

According to an official statement, it is mandatory for real estate promoters to

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | MONDAY | JUNE 29, 2026

Fuel crisis: Govt policies insulated consumers

KUSHAN MITRA

When the Strait of Hormuz shut to commercial shipping in late February, global oil markets did what they always do: panic first, adjust later. Brent crude surged from the low \$80s to well above \$115 per barrel in a matter of days, briefly spiking higher as traders priced in the possible disruption of nearly a fifth of global supply. Freight costs jumped, insurance premiums surged, and LNG prices followed suit. In much of the world, that volatility travelled quickly and visibly to the consumer.

In the United States, gasoline prices rose within weeks, with several regions seeing double-digit percentage increases at the pump. Across Europe, where energy costs were already structurally elevated, the shock was sharper. Governments scrambled for the second time in barely six years after COVID to cushion households with subsidies, tax cuts, and fiscal transfers. This has become a familiar cycle in advanced economies: allow prices to spike, then compensate after the fact, at high fiscal cost and political discomfort.

India did not follow that script. And it is worth stating plainly, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas managed this crisis with a level of control and effectiveness that deserves far more recognition than it has received.

While global crude prices surged, Indian consumers saw remarkable stability. Petrol and diesel prices did not mirror international volatility. LPG remained accessible at subsidised rates. There were no widespread

shortages, no visible panic buying, no breakdown in distribution. In a crisis defined globally by price shocks, India delivered continuity.

This was not luck. It was policy. The government made an explicit choice to shield consumers and then implemented it through coordinated intervention. Excise duties were adjusted. Oil marketing companies were required to absorb under-recoveries. Supply chains were actively managed. The state, in effect, stepped in as a shock absorber between global markets and domestic consumers.

The cost of that decision was substantial. OMC losses during the disruption are estimated at ₹35,000-₹40,000 crore, as fuel continued to be sold below import parity. LPG subsidies alone added another ₹20,000-₹25,000 crore in burden over three months, with Ujjwala beneficiaries paying ₹642 for cylinders that would otherwise have cost upwards of ₹1,600. Add to this the revenue foregone on fuel taxes, and the total fiscal impact comfortably crosses ₹1 lakh crore.

Critics will point to these numbers and ask whether such intervention is sustainable. That is a legitimate question. But it is also, in this context, the wrong first question.

Markets ahead: Fresh tension in West Asia, crude price to watch out for

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Developments on the geopolitical front, with the latest military exchanges involving the US and Iran, their impact on crude oil prices and domestic macro-economic data announcements would dictate sentiments in the stock market this week, analysts said.

Besides, trading patterns of foreign investors and progress of the southwest monsoon would also remain the key areas of focus for investors, they added.

"Market participants will closely monitor Industrial

Production (IIP) data, the final HSBC Manufacturing, Services and Composite PMI readings, and the foreign exchange reserves data for

fresh insights into the health of the domestic economy," Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

Globally, the trajectory of

crude oil prices and geopolitical developments in West Asia will remain key drivers of market sentiment, he said.

The monthly auto sales numbers on July 1 will also be tracked by investors closely.

"The week ahead is likely to be shaped by developments on the geopolitical front, with investors closely monitoring tensions in the Middle East following the latest military exchanges involving US and Iranian forces. While broader diplomatic efforts remain in place, the recent flare-up has reminded markets that geopolitical risks remain elevated.

Commerce Ministry calls stakeholders' meet on June 30 on SEZ issues

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The commerce ministry has called a meeting of stakeholders on June 30 to discuss issues related to Special Economic Zones (SEZs), an official said. The meeting will focus on issues related to the harmonisation of export promotion schemes and SEZ reforms, the official said.

The issues which are expected to figure in the deliberations include INR payment for SEZs to domestic tariff area (DTA) services; job work by units of these zones for DTA without linkage to exports, import

substitution, reforms in the free trade warehousing zones, and further promoting ease of doing business in these enclaves.

The government has set up a 17-member committee to suggest larger reforms in the policy for these zones.

It is undertaking a background study focused on

the harmonisation of various prevalent export promotion schemes, including SEZs, export-oriented units (EOUs), MOOWR (Manufacturing and Other Operations in Warehouse), Advance Authorisation (AA), EPCG (export promotion for capital goods), and Duty Free Import Authorisation (DFIA).

Board of Trade to meet on July 3 to discuss ways to boost exports

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Board of Trade (BoT), chaired by Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal, is scheduled to meet on July 3 to leverage benefits from recent trade pacts and to discuss strategies for accelerating the country's exports, an official said.

The BoT includes participants from various states, Union territories, and senior officials from the public and private sectors.

In the meeting, representatives of export promotion councils, along with other participants, will present their

views on the export sector.

"The BoT is meeting on July 3 here," the official said.

The last meeting of the board was held on November 25, 2025.

The meeting is important as India has implemented

Cooling products see mixed demand in June quarter

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Demand for summer-centric products remained uneven during the June quarter, as weather-related disruptions and higher prices weighed on the air-conditioner market, while categories linked to refreshment, hydration and impulse consumption continued to benefit from seasonal demand.

According to industry experts, air-conditioner sales slowed in June amid unseasonal weather and inflationary pressures, while beverages, ice cream and dairy products continued to register healthy growth, driven by immediate

consumption and affordability. Godrej Enterprises Group Business Head and EVP (Appliances Business) Kamal Nandi said demand across cooling categories has been mixed. "Refrigerator is doing very well, and demand is high both for mass and premium segments. Washing machine demand is also picking up as we are entering the monsoon season," Nandi told PTI.

DGCA probes incident of trainee pilot getting injured by aircraft

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Aviation watchdog DGCA is probing the incident of a trainee pilot sustaining injuries after being hit by a running propeller of a trainer aircraft at the Kanpur airport on Friday.

The incident occurred after the trainee pilot boarded the twin-engine Tecnam P2006T aircraft VT-NBV, and the instructor concerned has been derostered from flying training duties pending investigation, DGCA said in a statement on Sunday.

The aircraft, belonging to Garg Aviation, a flying training organisation, was engaged in night instructional flying at the Kanpur (Chakeri) airport.

"A flight instructor and a cadet were on board the aircraft. After landing, the trainee pilot boarded the aircraft with the engine running. The cadet received injuries in her back due (to being) hit by the running propeller.

Pijush Hazarika, Minister for Agriculture, Government of Assam, taking part in a paddy seedling plantation programme at Borkochari Gaon, Kondoli in Nagaon

PHOTO: KRISHNO KOMOL BARUAH

SHYAM VNL, one of India's leading developers of RF-cyber intelligence and mobile security technologies, successfully participated in the 11th International Police Expo & Wireless India 2026, held at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi.

The two-day exhibition witnessed participation from senior officials of central and state police forces, intelligence agencies, defence organisations, CAPFs, prison departments, government ministries, and security professionals from India and abroad. During the exhibition, SHYAM VNL demonstrated its comprehensive portfolio of RF-Cyber Intelligence, Secure Communications and Counter-Espionage Solutions, designed and manufactured entirely in Bharat for national security applications.

A major highlight of this year's exhibition was the introduction of SHYAM VNL's Technical Surveillance Counter Measures (TSCM) Portfolio, further strengthening the company's capability to detect, deny and locate hidden mobile-based surveillance and espionage devices. The launch complements the company's existing portfolio comprising EMPDPS (Entrance Point Mobile Phone Detection System), Secure Meeting Guard (SMG), Strategic Building Communication Guard (SBCG) and Vehicle Communication Guard (VCG), providing layered protection against modern wireless threats.

quintals against a requirement of around 17.2 lakh quintals, a surplus of 11.2 per cent for this kharif season. The private sector, which supplies nearly 70 per cent of seeds through a network of over 10 lakh retailers, has built additional buffer stocks over and above this.

The Government has identified 315 districts across 12 states that are likely to be impacted due to the delayed monsoon this kharif season.

Rana said nearly 50 per cent of Indian agriculture remained rain-fed, making the Kharif season acutely vulnerable to the El Nino weather pattern this year. (PTI)

- 18 Inferior, so it could be better (5)
- 19 Subdue, making a firm point (5)
- 20 A sad fate in Passchendaele (3)
- 21 Overheads involved in keeping warm (7)
- 22 Young listener's age (3)
- 23 Legendary flier? (6)
- 24 The horrible Mr Krueger's current form? (4)
- 25 Shifty fellow (6)
- 26 Pomeranian swimmer named Mark? (5)
- 27 Clubhouse! (5)
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- 30 Where to cultivate much for many (4)

ACROSS	19, Relic
1, U-boat	20, Prefer
6, Ladle	22, S-Ave
9, Good-man	24, Yep
10, O.G.-led	25, Foxtrot
11, Cello	26, Merit
12, Arrow	27, Cigar
13, Piscine	28, Wit-ch
15, Set	29, Red-he
17, Ugly	30, De-n-se
18, DIVID-E	31, Deeds

2, Bigwig
3, Agency
4, Tod
5, A-do-re
6, Laconic
7, Anew
8, Lil-Ted
12, Anger
13, Puppy
14, Sleep

16, Ten-e-
18, Divot
19, Refere
21, Re-vil
22, Stride
23, Vo-ic-
25, Fig-h-
26, Mars 2
8, Wad

 BRIEFLY

Scotland coach leaves after debacle despite new contract

Scotland coach Steve Clarke is stepping down after the team was eliminated from the World Cup even though he signed a new four-year contract only a month before. Clarke announced he was leaving in an emotional letter to Scotland's "Tartan Army" supporters shortly after Croatia's 2-1 win over Ghana on Saturday ensured Scotland could no longer qualify for the round of 32.

His seven years in charge saw Scotland reach its first World Cup since 1998 and qualify twice for the European Championship, having not done so since 1996. Scotland's players "deserve all the praise and adulation that they receive and it was truly an honor to be called their Gaffer (boss)," Clarke wrote. "Thanks for having me and good luck to my successor." Scotland played its last game Thursday in a 3-0 loss to Brazil but had to wait for days to see if it would end up as one of the third-place teams with the best records, and get a spot in the knockout stage. Its opening 1-0 win over Haiti was Scotland's first victory at any men's World Cup since 1990, but that narrow margin of victory ended up hurting Clarke's team after its subsequent losses to Morocco and Brazil. Goal difference was the tiebreaker among the third-place teams with three points and Scotland's minus-3 goal differential left it well adrift of Senegal, whose +2 goal differential saw it clinch the final spot among the eight qualified teams.

Iran narrowly knocked out of tumultuous World Cup

Iran has been eliminated from the World Cup, narrowly failing to advance past the group stage in a politically charged tournament where the team played its matches amid tight restrictions imposed by the United States. Iran missed the round of 32 by one spot in heartbreaking fashion. It finished third in Group G with three points earned with draws against Belgium, New Zealand and Egypt. Iran appeared to have advanced via tiebreakers when Algeria scored a stunning stoppage-time goal to go ahead of Austria 3-2 Saturday night, but Austria tied it back up seconds later on the game's final play. Their draw ensured Iran's elimination. It was one last painful moment for Iran in a World Cup that's been tumultuous, on and off the pitch.

The Iranians have been playing while Tehran negotiates with Washington on terms of a deal meant to permanently end the war that began earlier this year. Tensions continued Saturday when Iran launched a drone assault targeting Bahrain, home to the US Navy's 5th Fleet, in a likely response to overnight airstrikes by the US hours later, the US said it struck multiple Iranian military targets after it said Iran attacked a ship near the Strait of Hormuz.

Congo becomes 8th African team to make World Cup round of 32

MAURA CAREY
■ Atlanta

Africa had a historic 10 nations qualify for the 2026 World Cup. And now, following Congo's 3-1 defeat of Uzbekistan on Saturday night, eight are officially headed to the knockout stage. The previous record was two.

After 17 days of competition, Morocco, South Africa, Senegal, Ivory Coast, Ghana, Cape Verde, Egypt and Congo qualified for the round of 32. Algeria can advance with a win or a draw against Austria on Saturday night.

Morocco was the first African nation to reach the



semifinals of the World Cup four years ago in Qatar and looks capable of going deep again, having already held Brazil to a 1-1 draw. It is a co-host for the next edition of the World Cup in 2030.

Only six African countries

England beats Panama to win its WC group

RONALD BLUM
■ Foxborough

Jude Bellingham and Harry Kane scored early in the second half, lifting England over Panama 2-0 on Saturday and into what appears to be a more favorable bracket for the knockout phase of the World Cup.

On a rainy afternoon before a vocal pro-England crowd that made MetLife Stadium seem like Wembley, Panama held the European power scoreless through a first half when neither team mounted threats and Kane had 10 touches, the fewest of any player. Bellingham put the Three Lions ahead in the 62nd minute from Bukayo Saka's corner kick. Held in bear hug by Jorge Gutierrez at the top of the 6-yard box, Bellingham stuck out his left leg and stabbed the ball past goal-



keeper Orlando Mosquera for his third World Cup goal, his second this year.

Five minutes later, Bellingham crossed from the

left flank and Kane outjumped Andres Andrade to head the ball in for his 82nd international goal. Kane became England's record World Cup

scorer with his 11th goal, one more than Gary Lineker.

Wearing red jerseys in a tournament for the first time since beating Sweden in a

Lionel Messi becomes first to score in seven straight World Cup matches

SCHUYLER DIXON
■ Arlington

Lionel Messi didn't have much time to try to become the first to score in seven consecutive World Cup games. Argentina's superstar did it anyway as a second-half substitute.

Messi made it seven straight while extending the all-time men's World Cup scoring record with his 19th goal in Argentina's 3-1 victory over Jordan in a group stage finale on Saturday night.

In his first match since turning 39 three days earlier, Messi scored on a free kick after being taken down just outside the penalty box in the 80th minute. The low kick barely above the grass surface split two Jordan defenders into the left corner of the net.

It was his 72nd career goal on a free kick, including his 12th for Argentina. Messi now has 123 international goals — second all-time to Cristiano Ronaldo's 145 — in 202 appearances. Messi had been one of



only three players to score in six consecutive World Cup games along with France striker Just Fontaine and Brazil great Jairzinho.

Messi also scored on a free kick against Nigeria in the 2014 World Cup and is among six players since records are available dating to 1966 who scored two free kick goals in the World Cup. He joined Pele, Rivellino, Teofilo Cubillas, Bernard Genghini and David Beckham.

"I am very happy for him, for the moment he is having," Giovanni Lo Celso said in translated remarks after becoming the first Argentine other than Messi

to score in this tournament, also on a free kick in the 19th minute. "The truth is that seeing him every day excites, excites and infects a lot. So obviously seeing him like that for us is very important."

Messi didn't start because Argentina had already clinched first place in Group J, and the game was further meaningless because Jordan was already eliminated from the knockout stage.

Nevertheless, the decidedly pro-Argentina crowd of 70,649 at the home of the NFL's Dallas Cowboys was eager to see him.

Fans started chanting

Messi's name as soon as the second half started, and cheered loudly when he came off the bench merely to go through warmups.

The roar was louder when he stepped onto the field in the 60th minute, replacing Lautaro Martinez, who scored on a penalty kick in the first half.

For all the accomplishments of the eight-time winner of the Ballon d'Or as the best player in Europe, Messi has never won the golden boot as the top scorer in each World Cup. This is his sixth.

Messi now has six goals in this tournament, two clear of Kylian Mbappe, Vinicius Junior and Erling Haaland.

Messi had been dealing with a minor hamstring injury with Inter Miami that slowed him in the lead-up to the World Cup.

The knockout round for Argentina begins Friday in South Florida, and in this expanded 48-team tournament that would be the first of five matches in 17 days if La Albiceleste makes it to final on July 19.

2018 World Cup quarterfinal, England finished the group with two wins and a draw for seven points. The English play their Round of 32 match Wednesday in Atlanta, likely against Senegal or Congo. The team that advances faces Mexico or Ecuador in Mexico City. If the Three Lions had dropped to second, they probably would have faced Colombia or Portugal, with the winner meeting Spain, Austria or Algeria.

Panama went 0-3 for the second time and joined Iraq, Haiti, El Salvador, Canada and Mexico - all but one from the CONCACAF region - as teams that lost their first six World Cup matches. Jose Fajardo put the ball in the net for the Los Canaleros in second-half stoppage time, but was called for offside.

Supporters filled the field walls with Cross of St. George

Austria, Algeria both advance at World Cup with stunning 3-3 draw



DAVE SKRETTA
■ Kansas City

Austria and Algeria played to a thrilling 3-3 draw in what amounted to a win-win result in their World Cup group-stage finale, allowing both to advance to the knockout round while eliminating Iran from the tournament.

The game was tied 2-2 in the closing minutes, and the Algeria looked as if it was content to run out the clock, when Riyad Mahrez scored his second goal with about a minute left in stoppage time. That put Austria on the verge of elimination, only for Sasa Kalajdzic to head in the equalizing goal moments later and rescue Das Team's World Cup hopes.

Marko Arnautovic and Marcel Sabitzer also had goals for Austria, which finished second behind Argentina in Group J to advance for the first time since 1982. Its reward is a matchup with European champion Spain on Thursday in Los Angeles.

Rafik Belghali also scored for Les Fennecs, who became the ninth of 10 teams from Africa to advance. They finished third in the group but get a potentially easier Round of 32 matchup with Switzerland on Thursday night in Vancouver, British Columbia. Iran would've advanced as one of the eight best third-place teams had

Austria or Algeria won. But when Kalajdzic scored in stoppage time to tie the game one last time, it meant Team Melli was eliminated in heartbreaking fashion.

The first three World Cup matches at Arrowhead Stadium had seen the home of the Kansas City Chiefs flooded in the light blue of Argentina, yellow of Ecuador and highlighter orange of the Netherlands. But in Kansas City's group finale, the Algeria green and red of the Austrians were complemented by thousands of locals just happy to score a less expensive World Cup ticket.

Many of those locals appeared to be rooting for Algeria, which has made its training base in nearby Lawrence, Kansas, and has struck up a unique friendship with the small college town home to the University of Kansas.

Few of those new fans of Les Fennecs probably know about the "Disgrace of Gijon."

Yet longtime Algeria supporters had been waiting 44 years for some World Cup revenge. At the 1982 tournament, Austria and West Germany seemingly quit playing after the latter took a 1-0 lead, because that outcome ensured both would advance at the expense of Algeria, which protested to FIFA to no avail and was eliminated from World Cup.

A knockout win would be miracle; says South Africa's Hugo Broos

GREG BEACHAM
■ Inglewood (US)

This World Cup is already a landmark for South Africa, which had never advanced out of group play in its three previous trips to the sport's biggest stage.

If Hugo Broos' team goes even farther when it faces co-host Canada on Sunday in the tournament's first knockout match, the Belgian coach is ready to call that something even bigger. "If we should succeed again to get through to the (next) round, I can say that should be a miracle for Bafana Bafana," Broos said Saturday.

Broos took over this team five years ago believing that the nation with Africa's sixth-largest population and its largest GDP should consistently have one of the continent's best teams. Bafana Bafana, as the team is known to its fans, had won only two World Cup matches in its checkered international history - but Broos has built a roster consisting largely of players from South Africa's



domestic league into a talented, versatile team that is finally living up to its nation's potential. South Africa still had to open this World Cup in arguably the most difficult way possible — facing co-host Mexico's strong team in the altitude of formidable Azteca Stadium.

But Broos' players rebounded impressively from that 2-0 messy loss: They drew 1-1 with Czechia before advancing with a stunning 1-0 win over favored South Korea last Wednesday.

"I think we can say already now that the World Cup is a success for us," Broos said Saturday before his team toured the field at SoFi Stadium. "Everybody expect-

ed and hoped that we should be in the second round, and we are, but that doesn't mean we are happy. Once you are there, you want more."

They've been required to make a quick turnaround from that match, traveling from the match in the Monterrey area down to their training base in Pachuca on Thursday before getting back on a plane to Los Angeles on Friday.

But Bafana Bafana is riding an emotional high after achieving its unprecedented success. Defender Ime Okon said the players have been eagerly watching videos of the celebrations that broke out across their country near dawn when their team clinched a spot in the knockout rounds.

"It's a historic moment for us as a country," said Okon, who plays professionally in Germany. "We're just really happy and excited for it, and if we can go on, we will. We have a special group. We just want to see how far we can go." (AP)

Croatia beats Ghana to reach knockout stage

DAN GELSTON
■ Philadelphia

Luka Modric lined up for a corner kick intent on trying to float the ball to the top of the 6-yard box. Nikola Vlasic jumped high among the scrum and headed it in for a goal - good enough to advance Croatia in the World Cup and give Modric a slice of tournament history.

The 40-year-old Modric became the oldest player in World Cup history with an assist, and Vlasic and Petar Susic scored to help Croatia earn a spot in the knockout round with a 2-1 win over Ghana 2-1 on Saturday.

"I told him after the game, you play like you're 20 years old," Susic said. "He was incredible today. He runs a lot. He goes into every duel. He was incredible with the ball. He is our leader; he is our best player and we're so happy he can lead us in this World Cup. He can play until he wants, he's so good." Ghana had already secured advancement from



the group stage for the first time since 2010.

Vlasic headed home Modric's corner in the 83rd minute to score the winner and put Croatia back in contention after it finished third in 2022. The win means Croatia finished second behind England in Group I, with Ghana third.

"On the goal, I think I needed to do a block," Vlasic said. "But the ball arrived to me so I shot it with my head. It's not like it was some action but thank God the goal went in and we won the game."

Modric at 40 years, 291 days set the assist record back to records kept since 1966.

Colombia wins Group K after 0-0 draw with Portugal

ALANIS THAMES
■ Miami Gardens

Colombia's plan was nearly perfectly executed. The only thing missing was a goal. Didn't matter — it goes into the knockout stage as a group winner.

Colombia finished the World Cup's opening round as the Group K winner after playing Portugal to a scoreless draw Saturday night at Hard Rock Stadium in front of an electric crowd of supporters, the majority of whom were clad in Colombia's bright yellow jerseys. "We were the better team and deserved to win," Colombia coach Nestor Lorenzo said. "I think we created so many chances. We just lacked finishing. The players were outstanding against a top contender — not only did we play them on equal terms, we dictated the terms. I think playing against a rival like that, showing this kind of football to all these people, in this heat, was incredible."

He wasn't wrong.



Colombia had 24 of the game's 37 attempts on goal, never wilting despite the game-time temperature topping 90 degrees (32 degrees Celsius).

Both squads had already secured spots in the knockout stage before the match, needing only to learn their opponents for the next round.

Colombia opens the knockouts on July 3 against Ghana, which entered with one of the lowest FIFA rankings but also played England to a scoreless tie during the group stage. Portugal will face Croatia, which beat Ghana 2-1 earlier

Saturday, on July 2 as the Group K runner-up — potentially needing to go through Spain to reach the quarterfinals. "Win, losing or having a draw today didn't make a difference," Portugal coach Roberto Martinez said. "Our goal really is to play eight matches. The path for us really doesn't make a difference. We tried to win the match. Our opponent did the same." Both squads put forth lively efforts. Bruno Fernandez came close to putting Portugal ahead in first half, but was denied by Camilo Vargas.

2nd T20I: Ireland beat World champions India by 1-run to win series

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Belfast

Jai Moondra, a software engineer from Rajasthan's Tonk, rocked a star-studded batting line-up filled with IPL stars as Ireland did the unthinkable, shocking reigning T20 World Champions India by one-run to complete a historic 2-0 series win here on Sunday.

It is easily the greatest moment in Irish cricket since Kevin O'Brien's epochal century when they beat England in the 2011 ODI World Cup. But humbling of the mighty India will certainly be at a different level for them.

In a slightly nippy, blustery conditions, Moondra (3/32 in 4 overs), who still holds an

Indian passport, removed Sanju Samson (0), Abhishek Sharma (0) for first-ball ducks with icing on the cake being skipper Shreyas Iyer's wicket.

India managed only 153 for 9, chasing 155 at the Stormont ground on an eventful Sunday, after the hosts made 154 for eight.

Towards the end, Harshit Rana (21 off 10 balls) tried his best before being dismissed off the penultimate delivery of the match.

The series defeat also put a stop to India's 16 T20I series winning streak that started mid 2023. Under mercurial head coach Gautam Gambhir, Indian men's cricket team has achieved some embarrassing firsts. After a home 0-3 white-



wash in Tests against New Zealand in 2024 and a first ODI series defeat against New Zealand in early 2026, getting completely annihi-

lated by a minnow is one of the lowest ebbs that one could have hit.

Once it became 19 for 3, it was always a catch-up game for India. While vice-captain Tilak Varma (55 off 46 balls) respected the conditions where the ball was swinging and seaming. There was a bit

of spongy bounce and the odd ball stopped.

The IPL prima donnas decided to throw caution to the winds and never for once realised that they are not playing on the highways masquerading as cricket pitches which are on offer during the Indian Premier League with support of an Impact Player.

With Vaibhav Sooryavanshi breathing down his neck, Samson recorded his second successive first-ball duck against Moondra, who got one to shape in.

Three balls later, Abhishek, got a delivery bowled on hard length outside the off-stump and the southpaw's wild swig resulted in Matt Hollard running back from his

short third-man position to grab the catch.

Shreyas Iyer looked loose on both days, something not expected from a new captain.

Moondra slipped a stock left-arm's delivery that was pushed in with the angle and he got an inside edge onto the stumps playing away from his body.

Ishan Kishan (12) was back due to a brilliant direct throw by Ross Adair that found him way short of the crease.

At 35 for 4, it seemed all over for India when former vice-captain Axar Patel and current deputy Tilak Verma joined forces on a pitch that had a bit of carry and off the surface movement.

Earlier, debutant Prince

gave an impressive account of himself with three scalps while Shivam Dube bowled a double wicket over as India restricted Ireland to what seemed like a below par 154 for 8. Harry Tector (53 off 47 balls) and the dangerous Ben Calitz (37 off 23 balls) added 65 runs for the fourth wicket stand before Dube (2/25 in 3 overs) got wickets off successive deliveries that played its part in stopping the hosts well short of a par-score of 180. He was ably supported by Arshdeep Singh who also got two wickets. Dube first had Calitz caught in the deep and then bowled a perfect off-cutter that breached Gareth Delany's defence to hit the top of off-stump.

Russell starts on pole for Austrian Grand Prix aiming to reignite F1 title challenge

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Spielberg Austria

George Russell has a chance to put himself firmly back in the Formula 1 championship hunt as he starts on pole position for the Austrian Grand Prix. Russell took pole in a controversial qualifying session, setting the fastest time as a yellow flag was displayed for a crash by Max Verstappen. Russell argued he'd lifted off enough to be safe.

Russell hasn't won since the season-opening Australian Grand Prix. This is his third pole since then but he lost one potential win in Canada when his car broke down, and was beaten by the resurgent Lewis Hamilton



last time out at the Barcelona-Catalunya Grand Prix.

With Kimi Antonelli starting fourth, this is Russell's chance to cut into his Mercedes teammate's standings lead. Antonelli leads by 41 points from Hamilton and 50 from Russell. Charles Leclerc and Hamilton start second and third for Ferrari,

which has struggled on tracks like Austria where power is more important than cornering ability. A small engine upgrade for this week wasn't enough to bridge the gap.

"I think this weekend we've not been confident that we could fight for a win," Hamilton said after qualifying.

Perry, Gardner knock India out of Women's T20 WC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

Ellyse Perry oozed class and Ashleigh Gardner was all muscle as Australia notched up a smooth six-wicket win to knock an underwhelming India out of the ICC T20 Women's World Cup here on Sunday. The defeat could well mean the end of Harmanpreet Kaur's time as India's T20 skipper.

Perry (56, 38b) who is playing her 10th World Cup, and Gardner (53 not out, 29b), added 100 runs for the fourth wicket as the six-time champions chased down 171 in 19 overs to enter the semi-finals. The Aussies (10 points) topped Group 1 with an all-win record, while 50-over champions India ended third



with six points. South Africa also progressed to the last four with eight points after they defeated Bangladesh by four wickets earlier in the day. However, the Aussies were staring at the wrong end of the barrel at 68 for three in 9.1 overs after the

Indian bowlers dislodged openers Phoebe Litchfield, Georgia Voll and veteran Beth Mooney for precious little. Voll, in fact, fell in the first over itself, failing to negotiate Renuka Singh delivery that jagged back sharply.

But thereafter, Perry and

Gardner took apart the Indian bowlers with ease. They summoned years of vast experience to pick their bowlers and spots on the field to amass runs without taking undue risks.

Gardner punished left-arm spinner Sree Charani and Shafali Verma for sixes, while Perry was more subtle in her ways. The 35-year-old pulled and cut Sree Charani, Shafali and Deepti Sharma with ease and her knock was studded with eight fours.

But the effect was the same as Perry reached her fifty in 33 balls and Gardner in four balls less. Perry fell to Sree Charani, this tournament's highest wicket-taker, eventually but by then the Aussies had their one foot on the shores. Earlier, skipper

Harmanpreet Kaur made a quick 56 off 27 balls but rest of the line-up struggled for acceleration as India posted a slightly under par 170 for four, perfectly mirroring their batting group's struggle all along this ICC showpiece.

India did start well through openers Smriti Mandhana (38) and Shafali Verma (34), who added 66 runs but safety appeared their first concern rather than scoring fast as the run-rate never really went above 7. There were occasional flares of aggression like Shafali's two sixes off off-spinner Ashleigh Gardner or Mandhana's successive fours off pacer Kim Garth. India finished the power play at a rather fine 43 for no loss, but could have really stepped on the gas from that point.

Nagal wins his first ATP Challenger in over two years

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Indian tennis player Sumit Nagal clinched his first ATP Challenger title in more than two years after defeating French qualifier Felix Balshaw 6-3 7-5 in the final of the Intaro Open clay-court tournament in Targu Mures, Romania.

The triumph on Saturday ended Nagal's title drought at the Challenger level since his victory at the Heilbronn Challenger in Germany in June 2024. It was the 28-year-old's seventh ATP Challenger singles



title overall and his fifth on clay, underlining his affinity for the surface. Nagal, who has been trying to rebuild his ranking after a lean spell, earned 75 ATP ranking points for the title, a haul that is expected to lift him to around world No. 219 when the new rankings are released.

Indian trio makes cut at Czech Ladies Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Beroun (Czech Republic)

Former champion Diksha Dagar remained India's leading hope at the Tipsport Czech Ladies Open after staying within striking distance of the leaders despite slipping slightly in the second round with a card of one-under 69.

Her compatriots Pranavi Urs and Vani Kapoor also ensured a strong Indian presence going into Sunday's final round at Royal Beroun Golf Club.

Diksha, who won this



event in 2019 and has been enjoying an impressive run of form on the Ladies European Tour, carded a one-under 69 to add to her opening 66. At nine-under-par after 36 holes, she is tied-11th, four shots behind the leaders, and

well placed to make another push on the final day. The left-hander, who finished tied third at last week's Dutch Ladies Open, mixed four birdies with a lone bogey during another steady display.

Having opened the tournament with eight birdies, Diksha once again showed her consistency on a course where low scores have been the norm throughout the week. India also had encouraging performances from Pranavi Urs (67) and Vani Kapoor (70), both of whom comfortably made the cut.

Three others Avani Prashanth (75-68), Ridhima Dilawari (73-70) and Hitaashee Bakshi (71-81) missed the cut which fell at 5-under.

At the top of the leaderboard, Sweden's Lisa Pettersson and England's Charlotte Heath shared the lead at 13-under-par after producing another round of excellent scoring in scorching conditions.

Pranavi, who also recorded a top-five finish at last week's Dutch Ladies Open, signed for a one-under 71 after her opening 67.

Ben Stokes makes dramatic retirement announcement during Test match



STEVE DOUGLAS
■ Nottingham

England captain Ben Stokes made the dramatic decision Sunday to announce his imminent retirement from international cricket midway through the deciding third test against New Zealand.

"This is my last two days as your captain and my last two days representing England," Stokes told his England teammates inside the dressing room at the start of play at Trent Bridge on Day 4, in a video released on social media by England Cricket.

The match is headed to a fifth and final day Monday, with the series on the line at 1-1. The shocking announcement came 15 minutes before the tea break. Stokes picked up a wicket moments later and was given a standing ovation as he led England off at the end of the session.

"The reasons can wait (about) why," Stokes said in his dressing-room speech. "But I've had many trips to the well before for this team and I've got one more trip to do." Stokes, one of the world's most well-known cricketers,

has represented England for 15 years, the peak surely coming in 2019 when he starred for England in its wild win over New Zealand in the 50-over World Cup final at Lord's. He also was a key player in England T20 World Cup-winning team in 2022, the same year he became test captain. Stokes has decided to quit international cricket during a series when he made front-page news after being dropped by England for the second test amid an investigation following a night out with teammate Gus Atkinson after the first test at Lord's.

The two players were in a London nightclub when an England team security official was reportedly struck by a rugby player from English club Saracens. The England and Wales Cricket Board dropped Stokes and Atkinson, and later said they had "breached specific contractual obligations" and were given a written warning. The sport's independent oversight panel - the Cricket Regulator body - said after its investigation that there was "insufficient evidence to establish that any regulatory breach occurred." (AP)

New Delhi to New York: Ishani Sirohi flies India's flag and flies it high

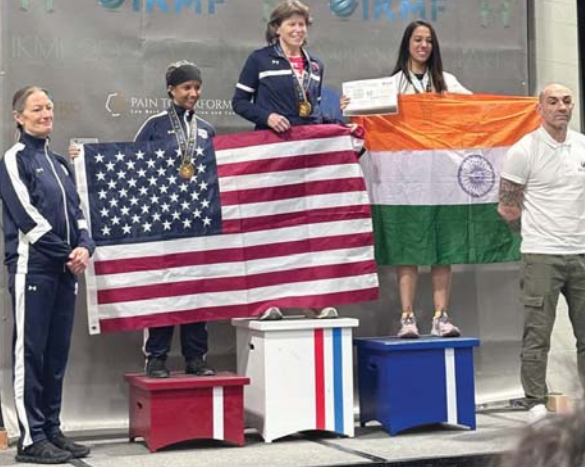
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

When Ishani Sirohi stepped onto the competition floor at The Oncenter in Syracuse, New York, the journey that brought her there spanned five world championships, six countries, and one unrelenting pursuit of excellence.

But perhaps the roots of that journey stretch back even further to a childhood shaped by two parents who served in the Indian Army, where discipline, sacrifice, and mental toughness were not lessons taught in a classroom but values lived every single day. It is that foundation that has come to define Sirohi as an athlete. Competing at the IKMF World Championships 2026, the New Delhi athlete delivered a performance that was equal parts power and endurance. In her marquee

event, the 30-minute Half Snatch Marathon with a 14kg bell, she claimed the silver medal, finishing second on the global stage and defeating athletes from numerous countries along the way.

The result was a statement as much as it was a podium finish. She also added a bronze medal in Military Snatch, rounding off a strong championship campaign. The event itself carried historic significance. Organised by the International Kettlebell Marathon Federation, the 2026 edition marked the first time the IKMF World Championships were held in North America, drawing over 300 athletes from more than 30 countries to upstate New York. For Sirohi, competing under the Kettlebell Sports Association of India, the national body affiliated with IKMF, it was her fifth world



championship appearance, and she arrived not as a debutante finding her feet, but as a seasoned competitor with a point to prove.

That competitive pedigree has been forged across years of relentless international campaigning. A bronze at her debut

world championship in Delhi in 2022 gave way to a gold and silver in Kyrgyzstan, two silvers in Greece, and a gold and bronze in China in 2025. A World Cup bronze in Russia further cemented her standing among the sport's global elite before this latest campaign on American soil.

Five world championships. Six countries. One athlete who keeps showing up and delivering. What makes these achievements particularly striking is the nature of the discipline itself. The 30-minute Half Snatch Marathon demands not just raw strength but extraordinary cardiovascular endurance, iron grip stamina, and perhaps most crucially, the mental fortitude to keep moving when every muscle is screaming to stop.

For someone raised in a household where pushing through discomfort was simply a way of life, it is almost the perfect sport. "This sport demands everything from you," Sirohi reflects. "It is not just about physical strength, it is about grit, resilience, and pushing through when your mind and body are both at their

absolute limit. Every championship teaches you something new about yourself."

Sirohi was part of a formidable Team India contingent that made its presence felt throughout the competition. The Indian team closed the championship with a collective haul of 23 medals, 5 gold, 11 silver, and 7 bronze, a result that speaks to the growing depth and ambition of kettlebell sport across the country.

For Sirohi personally, Syracuse is not a destination, it is a milestone. With five world championships behind her, medals won across four continents, and an army family's worth of grit running through her veins, the trajectory points in only one direction. The kettlebell may be made of iron, but the athlete lifting it is made of something far harder to forge.

Serena commands spotlight ahead of her Wimbledon return

KEN MAGUIRE
■ London

Iga Swiatek is the defending champion. Aryna Sabalenka is the No. 1 women's singles player. Serena Williams is the star, though, at Wimbledon.

The 44-year-old Williams' presence has been emanating throughout SW19 — the famous post code of Wimbledon — as she prepares to play her first singles match at the event in four years Tuesday when she faces No. 53 Maya Joint in the first



round. Mirra Andreeva, who just won the French Open, was basically crossing her fingers when the Wimbledon draw was announced. "I was watching like this because I don't think anyone in the draw would have wanted to play against Serena," the smiling Russian teenager said Saturday. "I'm going to speak for myself. I wouldn't want to play against Serena. I would be just very nervous."

Williams had been away from the sport since her farewell at the 2022 US Open

but she accepted a wild-card entry to play women's doubles with her sister Venus, who is 46. And then she accepted another to play singles. Williams' most-recent appearance at Wimbledon was in 2022 when she lost in the opening round to Harmony Tan, who was then-ranked 115th. The American great walked away from tennis — she described it as "evolving" away — after losing in the third round to Ajla Tomljanovic at Flushing Meadows.

Srikanth enters US Open final

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Fullerton (USA)

Star Indian shuttler Kidambi Srikanth edged out Japan's Yudai Okimoto in a three-game thriller to progress to the men's singles final of the US Open Super 300 badminton championships here. Srikanth, a 2021 world championships silver medalist, recorded a 22-20, 15-21, 21-19 win over World No. 33 Okimoto in 72 minutes to enter his first final of the season.



Srikanth, a former world No. 1, will meet World No. 46 Su Li Yang of Chinese Taipei in the summit clash. Young shuttler Rounak Chouhan's dream run at his maiden Super 300 tournament ended with a 17-21 19-21 loss to Su Li

Yang in the other men's singles semifinal. In the women's singles, sixth seed Devika Sihag, who won the Thailand Masters earlier this year, fell to Denmark's second seed Line Christophersen 21-15, 11-21, 15-21 in a 54-minute semifinals.

Srikanth vs Okimoto: Srikanth, now ranked 38th, made a bright start, racing to a 9-5 lead before extending it to 17-10. But Okimoto staged a remarkable comeback, winning 10 of the next 12 points to earn a game point.